Part

The Lottery and Other Stories

Practice Analytical Text Response Topics

Topics on *The Lottery and Other Stories* take the same three shapes as any Section A topic: **construction** (how does Jackson portray…?), **relationship** (how two ideas connect) and **idea / message** (what the stories suggest). Because this is a collection, the strongest essays draw on several stories, and often place examples from two different stories in the same paragraph. Treat 'The Lottery' as your anchor story: it shows almost every key idea and technique in the collection.

The four key ideas underneath most topics are **social judgement and exclusion**, **insecurity and dissatisfaction**, **unexpected events that expose our struggles**, and **the violence and cruelty beneath a civilised society**.

1. How does Jackson portray social judgement and exclusion?

2. Challenges to social expectations are treated as threats in Jackson's stories. Discuss.

3. Jackson's stories suggest that ordinary social settings can conceal disturbing cruelty. Discuss.

4. How does Jackson depict the pressure to belong in her short stories?

5. The desire for social acceptance shapes the behaviour of many of Jackson's characters. Do you agree?

6. Jackson's stories are tales of exclusion and isolation. Discuss.

7. How does Jackson portray the quiet despair hidden within ordinary lives?

8. In Jackson's stories, dissatisfaction is often a catalyst for imagining alternative realities. Discuss.

9. Jackson's stories suggest that the search for fulfilment rarely leads to happiness. Discuss.

10. How does Jackson use disruption to expose weaknesses?

11. Unexpected encounters force confrontation with uncomfortable truths. How is this idea explored in Jackson's stories?

12. In Jackson's stories, strangers often reveal what others would prefer to ignore. Discuss.

13. How does Jackson use everyday settings to make violence and cruelty more disturbing?

14. The most disturbing violence in Jackson's stories comes from ordinary people. Do you agree?

15. Jackson's stories explore discontent with identity. Discuss.

16. How does Jackson portray the conflict between individuals and society?

17. How does Jackson explore the relationship between community and conformity?

18. How do Jackson's short stories subvert traditional expectations of gender?

19. Jackson's stories suggest that respectable appearances can conceal disturbing behaviour. Discuss.

20. How does Jackson expose the cruelty beneath ordinary life?

21. In Jackson's stories, social expectations encourage intolerance and hostility. Discuss.

22. How does Jackson expose the darker aspects of human behaviour beneath ordinary life?

23. Jackson's stories reveal that the appearance of a civilised society can disguise deeply entrenched prejudice and a lack of compassion. Discuss.

24. How does Jackson reveal the reality beneath the surface of society?

25. In Jackson's stories, outward appearances disguise disturbing truths. Discuss.

26. In Jackson's stories, what appears safe and familiar is often unpredictable. Discuss.

27. Beneath the surface of ordinary life lies a world of fear and insecurity in Jackson's stories. Discuss.

28. To what extent do unexpected events create vulnerability and insecurity in Jackson's stories?

29. How does Jackson depict the pressure to conform to social expectations?

30. In Jackson's stories, appearances are frequently mistaken for reality. Discuss.

31. How does Jackson portray the gap between the lives people lead and the lives they imagine?

32. How does Jackson challenge the distinction between insiders and outsiders?

33. Jackson suggests that maintaining social order is more important to communities than protecting individuals. Discuss.

34. Jackson's stories suggest that the world is more frightening when everything appears normal. Discuss.

35. How does Jackson turn ordinary encounters into moments of crisis?

36. 'The morning of June 27th was clear and sunny.' In Jackson's stories, the most ordinary days hold the greatest danger. Discuss.

37. 'There's always been a lottery.' Jackson's stories show how tradition is used to excuse cruelty. Do you agree?

38. 'She was not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment.' Jackson's characters are trapped by their own expectations. Discuss.

39. How does Jackson use strangers to unsettle her characters' sense of security?

40. In Jackson's stories, the fear of being judged is more damaging than judgement itself. Discuss.

41. Jackson's stories suggest that it is difficult to belong without sacrificing who you are. Discuss.

42. How does Jackson portray the gap between how characters see themselves and how others see them?

43. In Jackson's stories, imagining a different life only deepens dissatisfaction with the present. Discuss.

44. Jackson's stories suggest that people create much of their own unhappiness. Do you agree?

45. How does Jackson use endings to leave her characters, and her readers, unsettled?

46. In Jackson's stories, children learn cruelty from the adults around them. Discuss.

47. Jackson's stories suggest that tradition is not necessarily a source of comfort. Discuss.

48. How does Jackson portray communities that protect themselves by excluding others?

49. In Jackson's stories, politeness disguises prejudice as much as it prevents conflict. Discuss.

50. Jackson's stories reveal that ordinary people are capable of extraordinary cruelty. Discuss.

51. 'Mrs. Walpole closed her eyes… harsh hands pulling her down.' In Jackson's stories, the individual is powerless against the community. Discuss.

52. 'Pretty soon they… they'll tell someone else to speak to me.' Jackson's stories show how quickly an insider can become an outsider. Do you agree?

53. How does Jackson use the recurring figure of James Harris to disrupt ordinary lives?

54. In Jackson's stories, characters rarely escape the roles society assigns them. Discuss.

55. Jackson's stories suggest that the desire for order can lead to cruelty. Discuss.

56. How does Jackson use domestic settings to explore dissatisfaction and conflict?

57. In Jackson's short stories, judgement is often based on fear rather than understanding. Do you agree?

58. In Jackson's short stories, belonging often depends on rejecting someone else. Discuss.

59. How does Jackson expose the dangers of prejudice and social suspicion?

60. In Jackson's stories, appearances are more important than empathy. Do you agree?

61. Jackson's stories warn of the dangers of blind conformity. Discuss.

62. In Jackson's stories, communities enforce obedience in both subtle and brutal ways. Discuss.

63. To what extent do Jackson's stories suggest that conformity comes at the cost of compassion?

64. Loneliness in Jackson's stories is both self-created and socially imposed. Discuss.

65. To what extent is anxiety inescapable in Jackson's stories?

66. Isolation shapes perception. How is this idea explored in Jackson's stories?

67. In Jackson's fiction, emotional insecurity often distorts understanding of reality. Discuss.

68. Jackson's stories suggest that ordinary life can be transformed in an instant. Discuss.

69. Routine and familiarity create a false sense of security in Jackson's fiction. Do you agree?

70. Jackson's stories depict moments when everyday life becomes unsettlingly unfamiliar. Discuss.

71. To what extent do sudden changes expose hidden fears in Jackson's short stories?

72. How does Jackson challenge assumptions?

73. In Jackson's fiction, disruption is often necessary for hidden truths to emerge. Discuss.

74. Politeness in Jackson's short stories often masks something far more sinister. To what extent do you agree?

75. In Jackson's stories, violence emerges most shockingly from everyday life. Discuss.

76. Jackson's stories reveal darkness beneath respectable appearances. Discuss.

77. In Jackson's stories, moments of calm and familiarity make acts of cruelty more confronting. Discuss.

78. Civilised behaviour in Jackson's short stories is little more than a performance. Do you agree?

79. Shirley Jackson's short stories reveal lack of satisfaction. Discuss.

80. Shirley Jackson's short stories consistently subvert societal expectations. Discuss.

81. How does racism affect the characters in Shirley Jackson's short stories?

82. In the world of Shirley Jackson, identity is constructed in response to the demands of society. Discuss.

83. How does Jackson use doors and windows to reveal the dissatisfaction of her characters?

84. In her stories, how does Jackson use the physical setting to convey the experiences of characters?

85. How does Jackson portray the inner frustration of ordinary lives?

86. Dissatisfaction in Jackson's stories is both self-created and socially imposed. Discuss.

87. Jackson's stories depict moments when the safety of everyday life becomes threatening. Discuss.

88. In Jackson's stories, ordinary life is both predictable and fragile. Discuss.

Introduction and Context

Overview

The Lottery and Other Stories (1949) is Shirley Jackson's only collection of short stories published in her lifetime. Its twenty-five stories are mostly set in ordinary places: New York apartments, offices, buses and trains, small towns and suburban streets. Jackson finds something unsettling in each of them. Her characters are lonely, dissatisfied or anxious to fit in, and her communities are polite on the surface but capable of exclusion, prejudice and violence. The collection ends with its most famous story, 'The Lottery', in which a friendly village gathers on a sunny morning to stone one of its own.

America After the Second World War

The stories were written in the 1940s, in the years during and immediately after the Second World War. Post-war America prized stability, prosperity and conformity: suburbs expanded, the ideal family was a breadwinning husband and a homemaking wife, and pressure to fit in was intense. At the same time, the war had revealed how ordinary people could take part in organised cruelty, and the late 1940s saw growing suspicion of anyone considered different or disloyal.

Analysis

Jackson's stories expose the anxieties beneath this ideal of order. Her communities enforce sameness, punish difference and turn on outsiders. When you write about conformity, social judgement or 'the violence beneath a civilised society', you are writing about fears that were very much alive when Jackson wrote.

Gender Roles

Middle-class women in the 1940s were expected to marry, keep house and raise children; single women in the city, like the protagonists of 'The Daemon Lover' and 'The Villager', lived with the anxiety of ageing outside these expectations. Men were expected to be confident, practical and dominant.

Analysis

Many of Jackson's characters struggle with these roles. Some, like David in 'Like Mother Used to Make' or the restless women of 'The Tooth' and 'Elizabeth', do not fit them; others, like Tessie Hutchinson with her dishes in the sink, play them dutifully until it is too late. Jackson shows both the pressure to conform and the price of conforming.

Race and Prejudice

America in the 1940s was deeply segregated, and racism was often expressed through polite, respectable behaviour rather than open hostility. Two stories, 'After You, My Dear Alphonse' and 'Flower Garden', examine this directly.

Analysis

Jackson is interested in the gap between how people see themselves and how they behave. Mrs Wilson thinks she is generous; the people of the town think they are protecting their community. Both stories show prejudice maintained by people who believe themselves to be good.

The Reception of 'The Lottery'

'The Lottery' was first published in *The New Yorker* in June 1948. It provoked one of the largest reader responses in the magazine's history: hundreds of letters, many angry, confused or disturbed, and some asking where such lotteries were held. Readers were shocked that a story could show ordinary, likeable people carrying out a murder as calmly as a town meeting.

Analysis

The reaction proves Jackson's point. Readers recognised the village as their own, which is exactly what made the story so disturbing. Its power comes from its ordinariness.

Shirley Jackson and the Short Story

Shirley Jackson (1916–1965)

Shirley Jackson was born in San Francisco and spent most of her adult life in North Bennington, Vermont, where her husband, the critic Stanley Edgar Hyman, taught at Bennington College. She raised four children while writing novels, short stories and humorous accounts of family life. As an outsider in a small New England town, she experienced the kind of suspicion and gossip her stories depict. She is best known today for 'The Lottery' and for her novels *The Haunting of Hill House* (1959) and *We Have Always Lived in the Castle* (1962), and is regarded as a major writer of psychological suspense and the uncanny.

Why the Short Story?

A short story has little room for explanation. Jackson uses this to her advantage. She often:

- opens with a description of the protagonist's ordinary routine or a pleasant setting;
- introduces an unexpected event, stranger or disruption;
- lets tension build through small, everyday details and dialogue;
- ends abruptly, often with the protagonist excluded, defeated or trapped, and without explaining what it all means.

The reader is left to fill the silence, and that is where much of the unease comes from.

Reading the Collection as a Whole

Although each story stands alone, the collection is designed to be read together. A figure named James Harris (or Jim, or Jamie) appears in many stories in different guises: a missing fiancé, a writer, a dinner guest, a neighbour, a stranger in a blue suit. The book is divided into parts introduced by epigraphs from Joseph Glanvill's seventeenth-century treatise on witchcraft, and ends with an epilogue: verses from the old ballad 'James Harris, The Daemon Lover', in which a mysterious lover carries a woman away to her doom.

Analysis

These links suggest that the strangeness in each story is part of a larger pattern. James Harris works almost like a demon or tempter who drifts through ordinary lives, exposing the dissatisfaction and fear already present beneath the surface. In essays, connecting stories through these recurring figures and motifs shows the examiners that you understand the collection, not just individual stories.

Structure and Themes in *The Lottery and Other Stories*

How the Stories Can Be Grouped

This guide concentrates on twelve stories that together cover the collection's key ideas. A useful way to study them is in groups:

- **Discontent and identity:** 'The Daemon Lover', 'Like Mother Used to Make', 'The Villager'
- **Cruelty taught and normalised:** 'The Witch', 'The Renegade', 'Charles'
- **Insiders and outsiders:** 'After You, My Dear Alphonse', 'Flower Garden'
- **Challenging or yielding to expectations:** 'Elizabeth', 'The Tooth', 'Of Course'
- **The anchor story:** 'The Lottery'

Unexpected Events Expose Our Struggles

Jackson uses unexpected events and strangers to expose characters' hidden fears, insecurities and dissatisfaction with their lives. A fiancé fails to arrive; a stranger knocks on the door; a man on a train tells a child a violent story. The disruption does not create the problem so much as reveal what was already there.

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

Jackson shows how people feel uncertain about their identities and dissatisfied with their lives, often imagining that another life might make them happier. The protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' is 'not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment'; Miss Clarence in 'The Villager' once wanted to be a dancer; Clara Spencer in 'The Tooth' drifts away from her own identity altogether.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

Jackson explores how social expectations pressure people to conform and leave those who do not fit in feeling judged, anxious and excluded. Mrs MacLane is frozen out of the town in 'Flower Garden'; Mrs Walpole fears her neighbours in 'The Renegade'; Tessie Hutchinson is cast out in the most final way possible.

The Violence and Cruelty Beneath a Civilised Society

Jackson reveals how violence, cruelty and hostility can exist beneath the polite and orderly surface of everyday life. Physical violence features in only a few stories, so think of this idea more broadly: cruelty, insensitivity, aggressive intolerance and a lack of compassion. Strangers mock, neighbours gossip, children learn to relish violence, and a whole village picks up stones.

Endings

Jackson's stories often end grimly, and these endings are some of the most useful evidence you have. Compare:

- ‘The Daemon Lover’: ‘No matter how often or how firmly she knocked, no one ever came to the door.’
- ‘Like Mother Used to Make’: David thinks miserably of his own warm home and hears faintly down the hall the sound of laughter.
- ‘The Villager’: ‘Her shoulders ached.’
- ‘The Witch’: ‘Prob’ly he was a witch.’
- ‘The Renegade’: Mrs Walpole closes her eyes, ‘suddenly feeling the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat.’
- ‘Flower Garden’: Mrs Winning ‘swung around without speaking and started, with great dignity, back up the hill toward the old Winning house.’
- ‘The Lottery’: ‘It isn’t fair, it isn’t right,’ Mrs. Hutchinson screamed, and then they were upon her.

Some endings shut characters out (exclusion); some leave them trapped in disappointment (defeat and resignation); some show cruelty becoming normal. Very few offer justice or resolution.

Language and Style

An Understated, Ordinary Voice

Jackson writes in a plain, calm, almost conversational style. She describes terrible things in the same tone as a morning's errands. In 'The Lottery', the stoning is introduced through the same matter-of-fact narration as the gathering of the villagers and their chat about tractors and taxes. This flatness is deliberate: by refusing to signal horror, Jackson makes the reader feel the horror of how normal cruelty has become.

Everyday Detail

Jackson builds her worlds from small, concrete details: coffee, dishes in the sink, the neat chairs in David's apartment, a lollipop, a bus ticket. These details make the settings feel real and familiar, which is what makes the disruptions so unsettling. They also carry meaning: the protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' repeatedly finds 'nothing to eat', and her lack of appetite suggests the emptiness of her life.

Dialogue and Polite Speech

Characters in Jackson's stories are often unfailingly polite while saying cruel or prejudiced things. Mrs Wilson's generosity in 'After You, My Dear Alphonse' is full of assumptions; the neighbours in 'The Renegade' cheerfully suggest ways to kill a dog; Mrs Harris in 'Of Course' imposes her views through seemingly friendly conversation. Listen for the gap between the tone of what is said and what it means.

Irony

Irony runs through the collection: a lottery whose 'prize' is death; a sunny summer day for a murder; a title, 'After You, My Dear Alphonse', that mocks performative politeness; a mother in 'Charles' who never suspects the badly behaved boy is her own son.

Unnamed and Symbolic Names

Some characters have no name at all: the protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover', 'the little boy' in 'The Witch'. This makes them seem anonymous and interchangeable, as if their stories could belong to anyone. Other names are pointed: Laurie suggests a crown of laurels, a symbol of glory; Walpole has been read as meaning 'foreigner'; Clara means 'clear' or 'bright'; Mrs Winning belongs to the family that always wins.

Setting and Weather

Jackson often sets disturbing events against pleasant weather. The village of 'The Lottery' gathers on a 'clear and sunny' morning 'with the fresh warmth of a full-summer day'. Ask whether the weather in a story reinforces ordinary life, contrasts with it, mirrors the characters' feelings, or creates an ironic contrast with them.

Open Endings

Jackson rarely explains. We never learn what happened to Jamie Harris, who the man on the train really was, or where Clara Spencer is going. The reader is left uneasy, and must decide for themselves what the story reveals.

Story Summaries and Analyses

The collection contains twenty-five stories. The VCAA 2027 text list sets twelve of them for study, and they are the twelve below: learn them well enough to use them flexibly across many topics. Jackson originally subtitled the collection *The Adventures of James Harris*, and a man of that name (or a man in a blue suit) drifts through many of these stories. Watch for him: he usually arrives just as a character's grip on her ordinary life starts to loosen.

'The Daemon Lover'

Summary : On the morning she is to marry Jamie Harris, an unnamed woman of thirty-four prepares anxiously. She writes to her sister Anne, agonises over whether to wear a blue silk dress Jamie has already seen or a print dress she fears looks too young, tidies her apartment and stocks food for their new life. Jamie does not arrive. By late morning she leaves him a note and goes looking for him. At the building where he said he lived, the superintendent and his wife have never heard of him, and the couple who lent their apartment to a man in a blue suit know almost nothing about him. The delicatessen man brushes her off, the newsdealer and a customer turn her questions into a joke, and the florist, while trying to sell her flowers, 'remembers' a man buying chrysanthemums. An old shoeshine man and a twelve-year-old boy finally say they saw a man with flowers go into a run-down house. On the top floor she knocks at a door and seems to hear voices and laughter, but no one answers. The other door opens on an empty attic where a rat watches her with an 'evil face', and she flees, tearing her dress. For weeks afterwards she returns to knock, morning and evening, but 'no one ever came to the door.'

Analysis : The protagonist is defined by deep-seated dissatisfaction: she is 'not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment' and hopes marriage will transform her life. In the 1940s, a woman unmarried at thirty-four faced real social pressure, which explains her urgency. The recurring lack of food ('There was nothing to eat in the apartment') suggests a life that is empty and hollow. Jackson slowly undermines the reader's trust in her: she cannot clearly picture Jamie's face, nobody official will confirm he exists, and the only people who claim to have seen him (a vague old man and a cheeky boy) are as unreliable as she is. The reader is pushed to re-read everything she has said. The title comes from an old Scottish ballad, 'The Daemon Lover', also known as 'James Harris', in which a lover lures a woman away with promises of a new life and then destroys her. 'Daemon' can mean demon, but also a guiding or inspiring spirit; Jamie is both, offering hope and then vanishing cruelly. The casual cruelty of strangers ('the boy grinned insolently at her') shows how easily individual suffering is dismissed. The real conflict is internal, between hope and reality, and the door that never opens is one of Jackson's starkest images of exclusion.

Links to other stories : Jamie's blue suit returns in 'The Tooth' and 'The Witch'; the lonely single woman pinning her hopes on a Harris reappears in 'Elizabeth' and 'The Villager'.

'Like Mother Used to Make'

Summary : David Turner shops carefully for dinner and returns to his small, neat apartment, which he has painted and furnished himself with great pride. He lets himself into the untidy apartment of his neighbour Marcia (she has no key to his, and he likes it that way) to leave her a reminder about dinner. Marcia arrives late, loud and hungry, and admires his home. David

serves a cherry pie, only his third attempt, and worries it is too sour. When Mr Harris, a large man from Marcia's office, calls by, Marcia lets him assume the apartment is hers, calls David 'Davie', and claims the pie as her own. David, unable to assert himself, washes every dish, is gently edged out by Marcia's hostess manner, thanks her for dinner, and accepts her key. He ends in Marcia's cluttered apartment, hearing laughter from his own home across the hall, and miserably begins to clean.

Analysis : Jackson contrasts David's control ('small quick movements', 'the neat small table and four careful chairs') with Marcia's disorder ('Marcia arrived with a shout and fresh air and disorder'). David's home is an extension of his identity, so losing it is a psychological as well as a physical displacement. His pleasure in domestic activities challenges traditional ideas of masculinity, and his passivity makes him complicit: he never tells Mr Harris the truth. Dramatic irony drives the second half, since the reader knows what Mr Harris does not. Cleaning Marcia's apartment is David's weary attempt to rebuild a sense of order and self. The title is ironic: the comforts of home 'like mother used to make' are made by a man and claimed by a woman who did not make them.

Links to other stories : The swapped identity in a borrowed apartment mirrors 'The Villager'; the home as a symbol of the self also drives 'The Renegade' and 'Flower Garden'.

'The Villager'

Summary : Miss Hilda Clarence, about thirty-five, came to Greenwich Village from a small town twelve years ago hoping to become a dancer, but now works as a stenographer. She carries a novel she read only 'up to page fifty and only carried now for effect'. Answering an advertisement, she visits an apartment to look at furniture for sale. The owner, Nancy Roberts, has left her a note to come in and look around. Miss Clarence finds the apartment dirty and the furniture not to her taste, but she lingers over a book of modern-dance photographs and tries one of the poses. Artie Roberts phones and tells her they are selling because he has the chance to go to Paris. When another prospective buyer, Harris, arrives, he assumes she is the owner, and she slips into the role, telling him she is a dancer and that 'Artie's going to Paris'. After he leaves, she writes a note for Mrs Roberts and returns to her own life.

Analysis : Harris's unexpected arrival is the catalyst that exposes Miss Clarence's disappointment with her life. She tells herself she has 'a good job' and lives 'better than she would have in her home town', but her props (the half-read novel, the occasional dance recital) show how much she cares about appearing sophisticated. The Robertses seem to live the artistic life Miss Clarence came to the city for (Arthur is an artist with a chance to go to Paris), so she simply borrows it. The dance pose symbolises her abandoned ambition, and the strain it causes shows how hollow the attempt is. The story has no climax and no change: the pretence brings only brief relief. The final line, 'Her shoulders ached', suggests the weight of carrying unfulfilled dreams.

Links to other stories : Compare David's lost apartment in 'Like Mother Used to Make' and Elizabeth's thwarted ambitions in 'Elizabeth'.

'The Witch'

Summary : A four-year-old boy, Johnny, travels on a nearly empty train with his mother and baby sister, looking out the window and announcing what he sees. Bored, he tells his mother he saw 'a big old ugly old bad old witch' and told her to go away. An elderly, friendly stranger

sits beside him. Johnny gives silly answers to the usual questions (he is 'Twenty-six', his name is 'Mr. Jesus', his baby sister is 'twelve-and-a-half'), and his mother corrects him. The man asks whether he loves his sister, then calmly tells a gruesome story about killing his own little sister, cutting her into pieces and putting her head in a cage with a bear. The mother is horrified and orders the man away, but the boy is delighted. As he leaves, the man and the boy share a laugh. The mother insists he was only teasing, gives Johnny a lollipop, and the boy decides 'Prob'ly he was a witch.'

Analysis : The story shows how children learn what behaviour is normal. The baby 'strapped securely to the seat' and the boy rewarded with a lollipop suggest a world of control and reward, yet the boy greets violence with breathless excitement ('Did you cut her all in pieces?'). Children in Jackson's fiction are often less bound by social convention than adults: the mother reacts with horror because that is what respectable adults must do, while the boy simply enjoys the story. The old man appears just after the boy imagines a witch, as if the fantasy has summoned him, and he is the only adult who takes the boy's imagination seriously. Evil arrives in a pleasant, everyday setting behind a harmless exterior, which makes it more disturbing. The boy's final explanation turns real violence into a fairy tale.

Links to other stories : The stranger who unsettles an ordinary journey recalls Jim in 'The Tooth'; children who absorb cruelty appear in 'The Renegade' and 'The Lottery'.

'The Renegade'

Summary : Mrs Walpole, new to a small country town, is rushing her twins, Jack and Judy, off to school when a neighbour phones to say that the family dog, Lady, has been killing Mr Harris's chickens and must be dealt with. Shaken, she goes to see Mrs Nash, who has already heard. On her way through town, neighbours offer increasingly cruel advice: Mr White suggests tying a dead chicken around the dog's neck, and the grocer and his customer suggest worse, in a tone of amusement. Lady comes home 'quietly, harmlessly', with flecks of blood on her legs. When the twins return, they gleefully describe a spiked collar that would cut the dog's head off if she chased a chicken, while patting Lady affectionately. Mrs Walpole goes outside for air but feels as though she is the one being punished.

Analysis : The title is deliberately ambiguous. A renegade is someone who rejects conventional behaviour; the dog is one, but so in a sense is Mrs Walpole, an outsider who cannot bring herself to have Lady killed. The neighbours' casual enthusiasm normalises violence: Lady kills by instinct, but the townspeople plan cruelty calmly and with pleasure. Even Mrs Walpole's own first impulse is to beat the dog, so no one is entirely innocent. She is alienated within her own family too: her husband barely notices her, and her children's delight shows how readily cruelty is passed on. Jackson drew on her own struggle to fit into a small Vermont town. The ending, 'the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat', transfers the punishment from the dog to the woman, revealing her fear of the community's judgement.

Links to other stories : The hostile small town returns in 'Flower Garden' and, at its most extreme, 'The Lottery'.

'Charles'

Summary : Told in the first person by Laurie's mother, the story follows Laurie's first weeks at kindergarten. He immediately becomes ruder at home, calling his father 'y'old dust mop', and comes home each day with stories about a boy called Charles who misbehaves dreadfully:

hitting the teacher, saying bad words, being kept after school. His parents are fascinated and amused, and ‘Charles’ becomes a family byword for any mischief. At the parent-teacher meeting, Laurie’s mother looks for Charles’s mother, then corners the teacher, who describes Laurie’s difficult adjustment in terms that match Charles exactly. The mother still misses the point, until the teacher says there is no Charles in the class.

Analysis : Laurie invents an alter ego to confess his own bad behaviour without being punished, while keeping his parents’ affection and attention. The clues are all there (his new rudeness, his stomping, his pause before naming Charles), and the reader usually guesses the truth before the narrator does, which creates dramatic irony. A second irony is that the mother is eager to meet Charles’s mother, not realising it is herself. Her unquestioning acceptance shows how parents see what they want to see. The comic tone hides a sharper point about how adults misread, and help create, children’s behaviour.

Links to other stories : The gap between appearance and reality also drives ‘Of Course’ and ‘The Lottery’; invented identities appear in ‘The Villager’.

‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’

Summary : Mrs Wilson is baking gingerbread when her son Johnny brings home his friend Boyd, a Black boy, who is carrying wood for their game. She scolds Johnny for letting Boyd carry the load and invites Boyd to lunch. Over scrambled eggs and tomatoes, she assumes Boyd’s family is poor, his father a labourer, and his mother overworked. Each assumption is corrected: his father is ‘a foreman’, his mother does not need to work, and his sister plans to become a teacher. Mrs Wilson then offers Boyd some of Johnny’s old clothes. Boyd politely says his family does not need them. Offended, she withdraws the gingerbread and says she is not angry, only disappointed. The boys, puzzled, go back outside to play, Johnny remarking that his mother is ‘screwy sometimes’.

Analysis : The title comes from *Alphonse and Gaston*, a comic strip about two absurdly polite Frenchmen who keep deferring to each other; the boys use the phrase to play at manners, and it frames their easy, equal friendship. Jackson uses it ironically to expose the gap between outward politeness and genuine respect. Mrs Wilson believes she is being kind, but her ‘kindness’ is built on racist stereotypes, and her withdrawal of the gingerbread exposes the ill-manners beneath her charity. The quiet, domestic setting shows that everyday prejudice can do harm without any open violence. The boys have not yet absorbed adult bias, which suggests prejudice is learned rather than natural.

Links to other stories : ‘Flower Garden’ shows the same racism hardening into a whole town’s exclusion; the innocence of children contrasts with ‘The Witch’ and ‘The Lottery’, where children absorb cruelty readily.

‘Flower Garden’

Summary : Young Mrs Winning has married into the town’s oldest family and lives in the old Winning house under her mother-in-law’s control; after eleven years the two women have begun to look alike, and she is ‘officially a Winning’. She once dreamed of restoring a small cottage nearby. When Mrs MacLane, a widow from the city, moves into that cottage with her son Davey, Mrs Winning befriends her, and their sons play together. Mrs MacLane transforms the cottage and garden into exactly what Mrs Winning had imagined. When Mrs MacLane makes Davey apologise to Billy Jones, a boy of mixed race whom Howard Winning has

insulted, and then hires Billy's father, Mr Jones, to work her garden, the town turns against her. Mrs Winning's mother-in-law, Mrs Harris and other neighbours pressure her to speak to Mrs MacLane, and Davey is left out of a birthday party. Mrs Winning withdraws and laughs at her friend in public. As the town's coldness grows, the garden begins to fail. After a storm brings a neighbour's tree down across it, Mrs MacLane wonders aloud whether she should give up and go back to the city, and Mrs Winning, watching, will not greet her.

Analysis : The townspeople act as gatekeepers, advising Mrs Winning to speak to Mrs MacLane 'about that colored man'. Mrs Winning's own fear shows how the pressure works: 'pretty soon they'll stop coming to me first, they'll tell someone else to speak to me.' When Mrs MacLane asks whether it is 'because of Mr. Jones working here', Mrs Winning denies it, then privately thinks, 'The nerve of her, trying to blame the colored folks.' Racism here is not one person's attitude, as in 'After You, My Dear Alphonse', but a whole community's, and it drives a family out. Mrs Winning is a disturbing protagonist: her own life is constrained and loveless, and her envy of Mrs MacLane's freedom, warmth and garden turns into cruelty. The cottage symbolises the life she gave up; her own dutiful nasturtiums contrast with Mrs MacLane's flourishing garden, which wilts as the town's hostility grows. Children reveal the town's values: Howard's racist name-calling towards Billy Jones shows how early prejudice is learned. The ending shows conformity and tradition winning over friendship.

Links to other stories : The pressure of tradition and the community against an outsider anticipate 'The Lottery'; envy of another woman's life echoes 'The Villager'.

'Elizabeth'

Summary : Elizabeth Style wakes from a dream of a warm, beautiful place to a grey, rainy New York morning. She has worked for nearly eleven years at a struggling literary agency with Robert Shax, who is both her business partner and her lover, though the relationship has lost its warmth. At the drugstore, Tommy, a young clerk, admits he has sent his play to another agency. At the office she finds that Robert has hired a pretty young assistant, Daphne Hill, without telling her. Over lunch she bitterly reminds Robert of Jim Harris, the writer whose signed photograph hangs on his wall and who left the agency after a quarrel. She turns down her visiting uncle, phones Jim Harris and talks him into coming to her apartment for a drink that evening, then dismisses Daphne, pretending it was Robert's wish. At home she buys drinks and crackers and waits, imagining a new apartment and a new life.

Analysis : Elizabeth's story is one of insecurity and quiet despair beneath a professional surface. Her small cruelties (to Tommy, to Daphne, to Robert) are signs of a deep unhappiness she will not face. Daphne, young, attractive and untroubled, is a foil who reminds Elizabeth of everything she has lost, and Elizabeth's sneer about whether Robert means to 'beautify the office' gives away her fear. Her name may allude to Elizabeth Style, a woman accused of witchcraft in seventeenth-century England. Harris is real, but his role in her future exists only in her imagination; Elizabeth is both a victim of the indifferent city and the antagonist of her own life, clinging to fantasy instead of changing anything. Like the protagonists of 'The Daemon Lover' and 'The Villager', she pins her hopes on a man who may never deliver.

Links to other stories : Compare the women swallowed by the city in 'The Tooth' and 'The Daemon Lover'.

'The Tooth'

Summary : Clara Spencer's husband sees her onto an overnight bus to New York, where she will see a dentist about a painful tooth. Dazed by codeine, whisky and lack of sleep, she meets a man who says his name is Jim. He sits with her, lets her rest her head on his shoulder, and speaks dreamily of a faraway place where 'The sand is so white it looks like snow'. In the city he reappears, holds out a handful of pearls as he passes. The dentist sends her to a surgeon to have the tooth pulled, and under the anaesthetic her tooth feels like 'the only part of her to have any identity'. Afterwards, in a washroom full of women, she cannot pick out her own reflection, thinks 'you'd think my own face would know me', and has to find her name on her belongings. She drops her barrette and a pin bearing the letter C into an ashstand. At the end she runs barefoot through what she imagines is hot sand, hand in hand with Jim, while passers-by stare.

Analysis : Jim represents Clara's desire to escape her ordinary, grey life. His poetic visions ('the waves ringing on the shore like bells', 'the grass is so green and so soft') evoke a mythical place far from bus stations and dentists' rooms. He appears when she is drowsiest and vanishes while she is with the medical staff, so the reader can never be sure he is real; he may be a symptom of her breakdown rather than its cause. Her name, engraved on a barrette and a pin, is a symbol of identity, and abandoning it marks the loss of her self. Clara's name means 'clear' or 'bright', ironic for a woman whose identity has faded. The whole collapse happens within a day, which makes it more dramatic. Unusually, the ending suggests escape from social expectations rather than defeat, though whether it is liberation or madness is left open.

Links to other stories : Jim's blue suit and promises echo Jamie in 'The Daemon Lover'; the dream of a warm place echoes the opening and ending of 'Elizabeth'.

'Of Course'

Summary : Mrs Tylor, eager for a neighbour with a child her daughter Carol's age, watches a new family move in next door and decides from their furniture and clothes that they are 'nice people, obviously'. She invites Mrs Harris and her son James in to rest from the move. In the garden, Mrs Tylor's suggestions keep failing: James does not go to movies, Mr Harris does not allow radio or newspapers, and he has gone to his mother's to avoid the stress of moving. Mrs Harris explains that her husband believes movies are 'intellectually retarding', and even bridge is out. Mrs Tylor keeps answering 'Of course'. As soon as the Harrises go home, Carol asks to go to the movies, and Mrs Tylor says, 'I'll go with you, dear.'

Analysis : The story turns on the pressure of neighbourliness. Mrs Tylor's first judgements are based on appearances; Mrs Harris then projects her husband's rigid views through friendly conversation ('it means such a lot to have really thoughtful neighbors'). Mr Harris never appears, yet he controls his family completely. The title is ironic: Mrs Tylor's repeated 'Of course' is politeness, not agreement, and her quiet trip to the movies at the end is her only act of resistance. Social conformity and the appearance of politeness are maintained, despite the intolerance beneath them.

Links to other stories : Polite surfaces hiding judgement also shape 'After You, My Dear Alphonse' and 'Flower Garden'.

'The Lottery'

Summary : On the morning of June 27th, the villagers of a small farming community of about three hundred people gather in the square for their annual lottery. Children arrive first, and

the boys fill their pockets with stones. Mr Summers runs the drawing from a battered black box, older than anyone can remember, assisted by Mr Graves. Slips of paper long ago replaced the original wood chips. Tessie Hutchinson arrives late, joking that she forgot what day it was. Heads of families draw slips in turn. Mr Adams mentions that a nearby village is talking of giving up the lottery, and Old Man Warner dismisses them as a 'Pack of crazy fools'. Bill Hutchinson draws the marked slip. Tessie protests that Bill was not given enough time to choose and that it 'wasn't fair'. In a second drawing among the five Hutchinsons, Tessie draws the paper with the black spot. The villagers, including her friends and children (little Davy is handed pebbles), stone her as she screams, 'It isn't fair, it isn't right.'

Analysis : 'The Lottery' is the anchor story of the collection: it shows every key idea. The pleasant setting ('clear and sunny') and friendly community ('Take your time, son') make the violence more shocking, and the title itself is ironic, since this lottery's 'winner' dies. The ritual is maintained by authority figures (Mr Summers, Mr Graves, whose name hints at death), defended by Old Man Warner ('There's always been a lottery'), who warns that otherwise 'they'll be wanting to go back to living in caves', and carried out by ordinary people. The old saying 'Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon' points to the ritual's origin in sacrifice for a good harvest, a purpose no one now examines. Mr Adams mentions villages that have given up the lottery, yet still joins in. Tessie is no rebel: she accepts the lottery until it threatens her. The detail that 'although the villagers had forgotten the ritual and lost the original black box, they still remembered to use stones' suggests that the violence outlives any meaning the tradition once had. Read as an allegory, the story asks which of our own traditions and scapegoats we accept without question.

Links to other stories : Every story above contributes a piece of 'The Lottery': the hostile town of 'The Renegade', the conformity of 'Flower Garden', the children who learn cruelty in 'The Witch'.

Story Study Guides

Use these guides while you read each story. Each one lists the ideas to underline and the symbols to circle, questions to think about as you read, and close analysis of key moments.

‘The Daemon Lover’

A woman in her mid-thirties is preparing to meet her fiancé and get married. As the story progresses, it becomes clear she has been stood up. Searching for him, she is confronted by the different lives of other people and their indifference to her plight. It is easy to assume the ‘daemon’ of the title refers to the demon-like way her fiancé stands her up, but ‘daemon’ also means a supernatural force that guides a person. Jackson is exploring how the protagonist’s own feelings drive her to the story’s fateful ending.

Annotate:

- **Unexpected events that expose our vulnerabilities** – ripped, torn or ugly things beneath an apparently calm surface.
- **Dissatisfaction with our identities or lives** – the neatness and orderliness of her apartment compared to the Roysters’ home; clothing.
- **Feeling isolated or excluded from wider society** – doors and opportunities being opened or locked.

Questions to consider:

1. Waiting restlessly, she realises she is ‘not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment.’ What does she hope to achieve with her marriage?
2. At the Roysters’, the couple are eating, their apartment is ‘full of music’ and their suitcases are out. How does this compare to her apartment, and what impression does it give of other people’s lives?
3. The story ends with her knocking repeatedly on a door. What might the closed door symbolise?

Food and emptiness. There are recurring descriptions of the protagonist not eating: ‘all this coffee… no real breakfast’; ‘There was nothing to eat in the apartment’; ‘In the drugstore she found that there was nothing she wanted to eat.’ Possible readings: food makes the setting ordinary and realistic; the lack of food suggests her life is empty and hollow; her life has left her hungry and undernourished; she is too absorbed by her obsession with a future husband to eat. The strongest reading is that the lack of food suggests the emptiness of her life.

Dressing for the wedding. She agonises over what to wear:

- ‘she wanted to be soft, feminine’ – she wants to present herself as an idealised bride.
- ‘it was very early in the year for a print dress’ – it is important to her that she observes the social mores of wider society.
- nothing about the blue dress made it special for a wedding day – she is torn between behaving suitably and wanting to celebrate herself as a bride.

- putting on her make-up 'was another delicate balance' between looking her best and deceiving as little as possible – she is balanced between portraying herself honestly and wanting to be thought beautiful.
- the print dress looked made for 'someone who would run freely, dance, swing it with her hips' – she feels like an imposter in her own life.

All these quotes show a woman caught between behaving as she thinks others will find appropriate and following her own heart. For example: *Jackson **explores** the protagonist's **personal desire to present herself** as an idealised bride through her need to be 'soft, feminine'.*

Word bank: *explores, highlights, reveals, demonstrates, represents + the tension between private desire and social expectation; the pressure to conform and private doubts; individual morality is easily suppressed when it clashes with communal norms; the desire to belong outweighs personal ethics; societal dictates can become so deeply embedded they override personal desire; the fragility of self against the behemoth of social order; individual identity and social behaviour.*

'Like Mother Used to Make'

The phrase 'like mother used to make' suggests recipes and traditions passed down through generations of women. It is never used in the story, but it reflects the domestic, orderly way David Turner lives. His sense of order is unsettled when an unexpected stranger disrupts his evening and imposes an outsider's view: the visitor assumes they are all in the home of a woman, eating food prepared by a woman. David goes along with these assumptions, humbly accepting societal expectations.

Annotate:

- **Conformity through judgement and social expectations of gender** – housekeeping (cooking, cleaning, keeping an orderly home), or being messy and slovenly (things broken or ripped).
- **Human isolation or insecurity** – keys, locks, doors; people being ignored.
- **The disruption other people bring** – unexpected events; being unsure how to respond.

Questions to consider:

1. How is David described at the beginning of the story, and what does it suggest about his personality?
2. When David starts cleaning, how does Marcia respond? What does this show about how each of them adheres to social conventions?
3. The story ends with David alone in someone else's apartment. What is Jackson saying about how hard it is to live a different lifestyle?

David and Marcia.

- **David:** 'David Turner… did everything in small, quick movements'; 'The neat small table and four careful chairs'; 'It pleased him to have only one key to his home'; it gave him 'a pleasant

feeling', the only way into his 'warm fine home'; 'He had chosen a sedate, pretty pattern'; 'He had always been partial to yellows and browns.'

- **Marcia:** 'Marcia's home was bare and at random'; it was 'too cluttered'; 'Marcia's bed was unmade'; 'The window had been open all day and papers had blown wildly around the floor'; 'Marcia arrived with a shout and fresh air and disorder'; 'She was a tall handsome girl with a loud voice'; 'Marcia was always hungry.'

Statements to weigh: compared with Marcia, David appears to enjoy traditionally feminine domestic activities; unlike David, Marcia is careless and immature, showing that Jackson disapproves of modern women; in contrast to Marcia's chaotic lifestyle, David demonstrates traditional male structure and routine; in comparison to Marcia, David is careful, controlled and highly organised.

At the end, David is isolated and excluded from his own home while Marcia is assumed to have baked the pie. **Sentence starters:** *At the end of the story, David is exiled by…; Jackson suggests that David's withdrawal is the result of…; In comparison, Marcia…; While Jackson presents David's isolation as a symbol of…, Marcia…*

'The Villager'

Like many of Jackson's characters, Miss Clarence is a woman in her mid-thirties who appears content but is prompted by events to reflect on an alternative life. She identifies strongly with being a 'villager', someone from the famously artistic, bohemian Greenwich Village. But she is now a secretary in 'smart clothes' rather than the dancer she once hoped to be. Inspecting the furnishings of a soon-to-be-vacated apartment, she imagines herself into its occupants' lives, revealing one of Jackson's ongoing concerns: people can feel both satisfied and dissatisfied with their lives at the same time.

Annotate:

- **Insecurity and dissatisfaction about identity, or satisfaction and confidence about self** – opening and closing doors; furniture and household objects; clothing.
- **Social judgement and exclusion** – household duties; men and careers.

Questions to consider:

1. Miss Clarence came to Greenwich Village because 'everyone who wanted to study dancing or sculpture' came there. What does this suggest about how individual she is?
2. Early on she is 'Miss Clarence'; at the end she signs her name 'Hilda Clarence'. What does this tell us about her sense of identity?
3. Jackson's stories often end with an action that sums up how events have made a character feel. What does the ending tell us about Miss Clarence's experience?

Judgements and gender. Miss Clarence is the only woman who appears directly in the story; Artie Roberts and Harris are men. As she walks through the apartment she judges its owners: 'she doesn't even make coffee in the morning'; 'Arthur was the artist, then, and Nancy…'. On the phone, Artie mentions he is going to Paris while his wife returns to her family in Chicago. Readings: society expects women to sacrifice their dreams; men have greater freedom to move through public life and careers; women are expected to quietly accept

disappointment; men are often emotionally disconnected from women's experience; women are expected to prioritise domesticity over careers.

Miss Clarence and Harris.

- **Miss Clarence:** 'she had come to New York… because she wanted to be a dancer'; 'The first thing Miss Clarence did was go to the window… But she could see only dirty roofs'; 'She opened the cupboard'; 'could Nancy, she wondered affectionately, be a dancer?'; 'She had already decided that she could not use any of the furniture.'
- **Harris:** 'I hope to write… Going to get a job and write nights'; 'This place is certainly nicer than mine'; 'He wandered over and opened the bathroom door; when he glanced in Miss Clarence winced'; he 'opened the kitchen door'; 'What I need is a wife'; 'I'm sorry about the furniture… Wish I could have found something.'

Both are hopeful artists without the lives they want; both judge the apartment; but Harris still believes in his future, while Miss Clarence can only borrow someone else's. **Practice topic:** *Shirley Jackson's short stories reveal lack of satisfaction. Discuss.* Starters: *Throughout her short stories, Jackson reveals…; In each of her stories, Jackson's characters demonstrate…; Although many of Jackson's characters expose their…; While both characters…; The parallel activities of…; On the surface both…; Although apparently similar because of…; In comparison to…; The contrast between…; The disparity between…; This is juxtaposed…*

'The Witch'

A young boy takes a train ride with his mother and baby sister. The mother keeps the baby quiet by constantly feeding her toast and largely ignores her son's questions and comments, casually teaching her children compliance. When a strange man sits down and tells the boy a shockingly violent story, the boy is delighted and the mother horrified. When the man suggests chopping off his little sister's head, the boy concludes that the man is a 'witch', someone who lives beyond the conventions of normal society.

Annotate:

- **Violence lies beneath the veneer of civilised behaviour** – excitement about violence.
- **Social pressure and parenting create conformity** – windows to an outside, different world; food and lollipops; the straps that hold the baby in a sitting position.

Questions to consider:

1. Strangers on the train tell the boy he is 'a fine big fellow', and 'These comments annoyed the little boy'. Why might he be irritated?
2. The boy tells his mother he has seen a witch out of the window. She replies, 'Fine.' How does this show adults modelling social norms for children?
3. Asked his age and name, the boy replies 'Twenty-six. Eight hunnerd and forty eighty' and 'Mr. Jesus'. What does this tell us about children's understanding of social conventions?

After the man leaves, the mother insists he 'was just teasing', but the boy decides he was more likely 'a witch'. Readings to weigh: the boy believes adults who don't conform to the rules of society must be mythical; the mother is trying to uphold normative values about how others

should behave; everyone finds ways of rationalising aberrant behaviour; children accept odd behaviour more easily than adults; the mother doesn't want her son to be frightened.

How children are taught to behave: the baby is 'strapped securely to the seat' (restraint); she is 'very quiet and busy with her rattle and her toast' (kept quiet and compliant); 'the little boy had a seat all to himself' (independence, and isolation); he 'ran across the aisle to pet his sister's feet and beg her not to cry… and the little boy received a lollipop' (good behaviour is rewarded).

Practice topic: *Shirley Jackson's short stories consistently subvert societal expectations. Discuss.* Vocabulary: *preserving social order, moulded by cultural expectations, restricted by conventional attitudes, conditioned to bow to societal pressure, behaving according to accepted standards, adhering to social mores; disrupting the expectations of polite society, transgressing conventional boundaries, resisting the expectations of others, defying the conventions of others, pushing against societal mores.*

'The Renegade'

A renegade rebels against the accepted way of doing things, and this story has two. One is Mrs Walpole, who has moved from the city to a small country town where she feels like an outsider, unable to conform to local attitudes and insecure about managing domestic life compared to her more capable neighbours. The other is the dog, Lady, whose killing of chickens becomes the catalyst for Jackson to explore the tension between Mrs Walpole's shaky identity and the apparent confidence of the people around her.

Annotate:

- **Social judgement and pressure** – household duties; time and schedules.
- **Violent attitudes and behaviours** – the dog's violence needing to be controlled through further violence; children's attitudes to violence.
- **Insecurity and dissatisfaction** – comparing yourself to others; Mrs Walpole over-identifying with the dog.

Questions to consider:

1. The story opens with a morning routine that has become disordered and rushed. How does the interruption make the protagonist feel?
2. In what ways does Mrs Walpole try to conform to, or make herself acceptable to, the town?
3. At the end she feels 'the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat.' Whose are the 'harsh hands'?

Mrs Walpole compares herself to the 'country folk' around her and feels an outsider, but that does not necessarily mean she is treated as one. Re-read the advice she receives from each townsperson. Statements to weigh up:

- The townspeople are outwardly kind and welcoming, but firm in their belief that a dog who kills chickens cannot be tolerated.
- Although they speak politely, their comments reveal an underlying judgement about her failure to control the dog.

- While many advocate harsh treatment, some offer gentler advice, revealing conflicting views about authority and control.
- Jackson presents the townspeople as practical and community-minded, valuing order and responsibility above personal feelings.
- The friendly tone of the townspeople contrasts with the harsh reality that they still expect the dog to be punished.
- The townspeople show sympathy towards Mrs Walpole, yet also pressure her to conform to the expectations of country life.
- Beneath the surface politeness of the town lies a strict set of shared values that outsiders are expected to accept.

Analytic verbs: *understands, suggests, implies, reveals, reflects, evokes, symbolises, sympathises, recognises*.

'Charles'

A little boy starts kindergarten and becomes fascinated by a delinquent classmate called Charles. Each day he tells his parents about Charles's misbehaviour: he swears, hits the teacher, punches other children and generally behaves terribly. His mother, who narrates the story, becomes so engrossed in Charles that she can't wait to meet Charles's mother. When she finally gets to school, she discovers there is no Charles at all, only her own son, who 'had a little trouble adjusting'. Through this twist, Jackson explores how insecurity and fear of social judgement can cause people to avoid confronting uncomfortable truths about themselves and their families.

Annotate:

- **Human insecurity and dissatisfaction** – the ways the mother describes the changes in Laurie; anxiety about how others behave.
- **Social judgement** – door slamming; creating mess; refusing to follow instructions or social norms.
- **Violence beneath the veneer of civilisation** – violent actions; interest in violence.

Questions to consider:

1. The narrator describes her son as 'a long-trousered, swaggering character'. What other clues show that 'Charles' is really Laurie?
2. How do both parents encourage the idea that misbehaviour is interesting and worth talking about?
3. At the end, the mother suggests Laurie's 'trouble adjusting' is due to Charles's influence. What does this say about her belief that her son's behaviour comes from outside influences?

Sentence starters: *Many of Jackson's characters fear social judgement and...; Characters in Jackson's short stories frequently internalise the expectations of society and become harsh critics of...; The insecurity of characters like..., who believes...; The societal expectation to... puts pressure on...*

‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’

Mrs Wilson makes a range of assumptions about the family life, finances and values of her son’s African-American friend, Boyd. This culminates in her angry reaction to his lack of gratitude for her ‘charitable’ offer of second-hand clothes, which Boyd and his family do not need because they are not, as she assumes, poor. Beyond exposing Mrs Wilson’s subtle racism, Jackson critiques the way people’s assumptions maintain social divisions and the established order.

Annotate:

- **Communities enforce conformity through social pressure** – food used to control behaviour and interactions.
- **Social judgement and assumptions** – food and clothes representing social status and values.

Questions to consider:

1. Johnny and Boyd play army tanks, ‘running over’ Japanese soldiers who fought against the United States in the Second World War. What does this suggest about how prejudice can be passed on to children?
2. What assumptions does Mrs Wilson make about Boyd’s family, and what do they reveal about her world-view?
3. Mrs Wilson says, ‘Don’t think I’m angry, Boyd. I’m just disappointed in you.’ What word more accurately describes how she feels?

The title. The boys use the phrase when they politely invite each other through a doorway. It comes from a comic strip in which two overly polite Frenchmen constantly defer to each other, satirising performative, superficial politeness that hides self-interest. Readings: the refined phrase challenges Mrs Wilson’s assumption that Boyd comes from an uneducated or disadvantaged background; the title highlights that her stereotypes are inaccurate and based on prejudice; it reflects manners and cultural awareness she does not expect Boyd to have; its exaggerated politeness mocks people like Mrs Wilson who perform kindness while holding racist attitudes; Jackson uses it ironically to expose the gap between outward politeness and genuine respect.

Endings. Jackson’s stories often end with a brief, powerful line that reveals the protagonist’s emotional state, isolation or identity, leaving judgement, discomfort or tension. In ‘The Villager’, ‘Her shoulders ached’ suggests how burdened Miss Clarence has become by her attempt to maintain an artistic persona. In ‘The Daemon Lover’, ‘No matter how often or how firmly she knocked, no one ever came to the door’ reinforces the protagonist’s isolation and suggests her search for connection, certainty and identity will remain unresolved. Try: *In ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, Boyd’s concluding agreement that his mother is ‘screwy’ suggests that parents are…*; *At the very end, Boyd’s use of the catchphrase ‘After you, my dear Alphonse’ reinforces…*

‘Flower Garden’

Mrs MacLane, a recent widow, moves to a country town, renovates a long-unoccupied cottage, grows a rich flower garden and befriends Mrs Winning. Mrs Winning is drawn to her lifestyle,

seeing in the cottage and garden the life she might have had instead of the dreariness of her own home, where she lives mired in routine with her parents-in-law. But Mrs MacLane's decision to hire an African-American man to help in her garden exposes the prejudice of the townspeople. Faced with being associated with Mrs MacLane's transgression, Mrs Winning retreats to the safety of conforming to the town's judgement.

Annotate:

- **Communities enforcing conformity** – schedules and routines; traditions; characters feeling helpless.
- **Insecurity and dissatisfaction** – being alone; looking at and admiring other people's belongings.
- **Unexpected events or strangers disrupting routines and assumptions** – grey tones contrasted with images of colour; surprised reactions.

Questions to consider:

1. The two Mrs Winnings 'had grown to look a good deal alike', and 'uncounted Winning children had played with almost identical toys'. What do these details suggest about Mrs Winning's sense of herself as an individual?
2. Several characters tell Mrs Winning she should talk to Mrs MacLane 'about that colored man'. No one ever says exactly what the problem is. What does this show about the power of unspoken attitudes in the town?
3. Mrs Winning feels differently about walking up the hill to her house at different points. Describe two of these feelings and their causes.

Mrs Winning and Mrs MacLane. House: 'This dreary old place' against Mrs MacLane's renovated cottage. Garden: the Winnings' plain yard against a house surrounded by beautiful flowers. Child: Mrs Winning doesn't show physical affection; Mrs MacLane's son Davey becomes Howard's friend. Husband: Mrs Winning lives under her husband's family; Mrs MacLane is on her own now he is dead. Independence: Mrs MacLane 'had some money in her own name'. Clothing: Mrs Winning puts 'a scarf over her head'; Mrs MacLane wears a rose-coloured sweater, 'a spot of color' in the room.

The townspeople's role. When they advise Mrs Winning to speak to Mrs MacLane, which label fits best? *Critics* (people who judge and disapprove of others), *followers* (who go along with others' opinions), *gatekeepers* (who decide who is accepted or excluded), *cultural guardians* (who protect a community's traditions and values), *insiders* (people accepted within the group).

The name 'Winning'. 'Winning' means victory, yet Mrs Winning experiences the opposite at several points in the story. Vocabulary: *the name reflects her desire to..., the name stands in contrast to..., her name is both..., the symbolism of her name reflects..., the connotations of her name; defeated by the reality of life, trapped by social expectations, confined by social convention, restricted by inherited traditions, unable to escape the pressures of society; the bittersweet victory of conformity, the safety of her position, the privilege of social approval, the quiet power of social acceptance, the rewards of compliance*.

'Elizabeth'

As one of Jackson's clearly named characters, Elizabeth seems to know who she is and what she wants. But other characters call her 'Miss Style', 'Liz' and 'Beth', identities she clearly struggles with. She runs a literary agency with Robbie, an ineffectual man who bumbles through life and work, constantly relying on her for direction. The agency is struggling, weighed down by Robbie's incompetence and his pattern of damaging relationships. By the end Elizabeth has had enough, arranging a meeting with an old client and imagining he may offer her a pathway to a better, more independent life.

Annotate:

- **Conformity through years of habit** – the rituals Elizabeth and Robbie share; meals and drinks.
- **Human isolation, insecurity and dissatisfaction** – being alone; looking through windows; being separated by rooms, partitions or doors; grey tones contrasted with colour.
- **Strangers disrupting any sense of security** – new and different colours, actions and behaviours.
- **A shifting sense of identity** – imagining alternative lifestyles; thinking about the past; names.

Questions to consider:

1. Elizabeth is woken from a dream: 'Just before the alarm went off she was lying in a hot sunny garden', and when she opened her eyes 'it was raining'. How does this contrast show her dreaming of two different lives?
2. Jackson calls her Elizabeth, but others call her 'Liz' or 'Beth'. How do these names show the different roles she plays?
3. At the end she tries to make her apartment more welcoming. What do her actions show about the life she was expected to lead and her current reality?

Gender. The story asks whether Elizabeth meets the expectations of 1940s femininity. Traits often coded as masculine: dismissive of emotional vulnerability, socially dominant, self-assured, uncomfortable with emotional intimacy, confident in public, defined by practicality rather than imagination. Traits often coded as feminine: emotionally perceptive and sensitive, anxious about social acceptance, conditioned to seek approval, responsible for domestic beauty and order, using imagination as escapism, attentive to appearances, dutiful to family. Elizabeth shows traits from both lists: she is a complex character trying to fit a world with restrictive norms around gender.

Practice topic: *How do Jackson's short stories subvert traditional expectations of gender?* Starters: *Set in a world of conventional gender roles…; In Jackson's stories, traditional gender roles are…; Jackson subverts every expectation of…; As they go about their lives, Jackson's female characters feel constrained to…; The male characters in Jackson's stories are bound by… + challenges, resists, disrupts, reframes, redefines, exposes the fragility of, rejects prescribed, unsettles the boundaries between* or *complies with, accepts, submits to, accommodates, adheres to, upholds, embraces the safety of, conforms outwardly, maintains appearances*.

'The Tooth'

One of the stranger stories in the collection, partly because much of the action is a dreamlike sequence. The protagonist travels to New York to see a dentist about her aching tooth, taking a great many painkillers. Her feverish dreams symbolise a different life she could live, and as the boundary between reality and fantasy blurs, Jackson alludes to the appeal of escaping an ordinary, suburban existence.

Annotate:

- **Dissatisfaction, a shifting sense of identity and isolation** – mirrors; physical appearances; torn, ripped or broken things; colourlessness contrasted with bright colours; dreams; uncertainty.
- **Strangers disrupting routines and assumptions** – sudden consciousness and unconsciousness; strangers.

Questions to consider:

1. Many stories open with a description of everyday routine. What does Jackson describe at the start of this story to show what normal life is like for the protagonist?
2. For most of the story she is unnamed, until she finds the name 'Clara' written on one of her belongings. Clara means 'clear' or 'bright'. What is significant about this?
3. Jackson often ends with the protagonist trapped or dissatisfied. Is this how 'The Tooth' ends? Compare it with another story's ending.

Jim, the man in the blue suit. The colour of his suit and his confidence contrast with her uncertainty and the greyness of her sense of self. He describes a place far removed from buses, truck-stop restaurants and dentists' rooms: 'the waves ringing on the shore like bells', 'nothing to do all day but lie under the trees', 'The grass is so green and so soft'. He evokes legends of Samarkand, an almost mythical place on the Silk Road, the ancient route along which traders carried cloth, spices, information and stories. Readings: she imagines Jim because he represents her desire to escape her ordinary, everyday life; Jim is simply a friendly stranger who comforts her; she uses the thought of Jim to transform herself into a different, more glamorous person; speaking lines of poetic beauty, Jim symbolises the possibility of becoming someone else.

Doors, windows and mirrors. As in 'The Daemon Lover', 'Like Mother Used to Make' and 'The Villager', doors and windows offer visions of a different life or opportunities, sometimes closed, that the protagonist could access. Vocabulary: *thresholds into another self, glimpses of a parallel life, …onto unrealised possibilities, …to hidden identities, openings into alternate realities, portals to a different existence, reflections of lives not lived, moments of escape from…, windows into forbidden desires, doorways to self-discovery, glimpses beyond domesticity, openings into emotional truth, thresholds between reality and fantasy, …onto hidden inner worlds, passages into uncertain futures, doorways to reinvention*. Practice question: *How does Jackson use doors and windows to reveal the dissatisfaction of her characters?*

'Of Course'

Mrs Harris moves in next door to Mrs Tylor. Mrs Tylor immediately profiles her and judges that the family must be 'nice people, obviously', another of Jackson's characters wanting a

world that safely conforms to her sense of what is normal and respectable. But Mrs Harris is not the kind of 'nice' person Mrs Tylor hoped for. She lists the forms of media and entertainment her family avoids, and Mrs Tylor becomes increasingly unsettled by their differences. Throughout her growing discomfort she can only answer 'of course', highlighting both her fear of open disagreement and the ease with which she conforms to her own sense of propriety.

Annotate:

- **Communities enforce conformity through expectations and social pressure** – approval of clothes and appearance; assumptions.
- **Unexpected events or strangers disrupting routines and assumptions** – new people; housekeeping routines; other lifestyles.

Questions to consider:

1. Mrs Tylor is 'far too polite' to go outside and stare at her new neighbours, yet she watches in a particular way as she does her chores. What does this tell us about what she thinks is 'polite'?
2. Mrs Tylor stays polite even as it becomes clear their values differ, while her daughter Carol behaves 'sullenly' towards the new neighbour's son. Who is more honest about their feelings?
3. At the end, Mrs Tylor says she will go with her daughter to the movies. Why is this significant in the context of the story?

Neighbourliness and conformity.

- Mrs Tylor 'recognized finally the faint nervous feeling that was tagging her; it was the way she felt when she was irrevocably connected with something dangerously out of control' – characters feel uneasy when neighbours do not behave in predictable or conventional ways.
- 'Carol shut her mouth obstinately and the little boy edged behind his mother' – neighbourly relationships can reveal the tension between personal choice and social expectation.
- Mrs Tylor approves of the woman's 'nice-looking tan suit': 'Nice people, obviously' – it is important for neighbours to fit accepted notions of respectability.
- Mrs Tylor: 'There's something so nice about congenial people right next door' – neighbourliness is meant to involve easy social interactions.
- Mrs Harris: 'it means such a lot to have really thoughtful neighbors' – being a 'good neighbour' can mean behaving in ways others see as conforming to their values.

Vocabulary: *social pressure, expectations, fitting in, acceptance, social norms, desire to belong, fear of judgement, expectations of neighbourly behaviour, pressure to appear polite, discomfort with difference; conventional, neighbourly, agreeable, uncomfortable, judgemental; highlights, reveals, challenges, resists, contrasts, suggests*.

'The Lottery'

A lottery is a form of gambling in which names or tickets are placed in a box and one is drawn at random, usually to win a prize. Because lotteries are so familiar, Jackson presents the ritual as calm, ordinary and completely accepted. The villagers gather, chat and wait as though

taking part in a harmless community tradition, and this unsettling normality gives the story its disturbing atmosphere. Gradually the reader discovers that the 'winner' receives no reward but is violently sacrificed by the community. Through this shocking ending, Jackson shows how societies can destroy individuality and morality through blind conformity to tradition.

Character	First half of the story	End of the story
Tessie Hutchinson	Arrives late, joking and chatting casually with neighbours. Becomes anxious and upset when her family is selected.	Draws the marked paper and protests that it 'isn't fair' as the villagers stone her.
Bill Hutchinson	Quietly participates and draws the marked paper for his family in the first round.	Forces the slip of paper out of Tessie's hand, revealing the black spot.
Mr Summers	Runs the lottery, as he runs the square dances and the teen club; worries about the shabby black box.	Oversees the final selection and keeps the ritual moving efficiently.
Old Man Warner	Defends the tradition and criticises villages that want to stop it.	Urges the villagers on as they close in.
Mrs Delacroix	Chats in a friendly way with Tessie at the start.	Picks up a stone so large she needs both hands and helps kill Tessie.
Mr Adams	Mentions that other villages are talking of giving up the lottery.	Still participates in the stoning, at the front of the crowd.
Davy Hutchinson	Waits with his family during the drawing and takes part in the ritual as a child of the community.	Is given a few pebbles to throw.
Bobby Martin	Collects stones with the other boys before the lottery begins.	The children, who gathered the stones, join in.

Roles in a society: the characters can be labelled *enforcer, traditionalist, scapegoat, bystander, organiser, follower, enabler, accomplice, dissenter, conformist, victim, outcast*.

Tessie as a transgressor. Although Tessie's name is drawn at random, her early actions position her as a transgressor: she comes late because she 'Clean forgot what day it was'. Forgetting the lottery suggests a small, perhaps unconscious, distance from the tradition that sets her slightly apart from the community before chance singles her out.

The anchor story. 'The Lottery' powerfully represents almost every idea in the collection:

- **Isolation, insecurity and dissatisfaction:** Tessie becomes completely isolated once the crowd turns against her; the villagers hide their fear and insecurity beneath cheerful small talk and routine.
- **Social judgement and exclusion:** Tessie is cast out the moment she is chosen; compare Mrs MacLane, ostracised for hiring a Black gardener in 'Flower Garden', and Boyd, judged through racist stereotypes in 'After You, My Dear Alphonse'.
- **Communities enforce conformity through traditions, rituals and social pressure:** the villagers continue the lottery because social pressure and tradition discourage anyone from resisting.
- **Unexpected events disrupting routines and assumptions:** Tessie's selection suddenly transforms an ordinary community gathering into a horrifying event.

- **Violence beneath the veneer of civilised behaviour:** neighbours, friends and family carry out a killing as calmly as a town meeting.
- **A shifting sense of identity:** Tessie shifts from a cheerful member of the community to an isolated victim once she is selected.

Connecting the Stories

When you study a collection, you need to make connections between stories that can seem completely different. The activities below practise linking stories through shared ideas, symbols and character types, which is exactly what high-scoring Section A essays do.

Naming, or Not Naming, Protagonists

Many of Jackson's protagonists have no name. The protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' is never named, although her fiancé and many people she meets are. By contrast, David Turner's name opens 'Like Mother Used to Make'.

Describing the two protagonists. The protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' is *nebulous, unsure, uncertain, undecided, operating in a liminal space, between life stages, doubtful, searching for direction, plagued by self-doubt, torn between possibilities* (of/about herself, who she is, her identity, who she would like to be). David Turner is *definite, particular, sure, individual, well defined, set in his habits, secure, clear about, guided by firm principles, anchored by routine* (about himself, who he is, his identity, his aspirations).

Model paragraph:

> *Many of Jackson's unnamed characters exist in a state of uncertainty about who they are, while characters with names often appear more stable and confident. In 'The Daemon Lover', the unnamed protagonist wanders through the city searching for her missing fiancé. Her lack of a name reflects her weak sense of identity and how much she depends on becoming a 'bride-to-be'. As she moves through apartments, streets and memories, she struggles to define herself outside the expectations of romance and marriage. Jackson develops this uncertainty through the protagonist's fragmented thoughts and growing paranoia, suggesting that her identity is fragile and unstable. By contrast, in 'Like Mother Used to Make', David Turner's full name makes him seem more socially established and certain of his place in the world. However, Jackson still reveals cracks beneath this confidence as David desperately tries to appear sophisticated and domestically capable in front of Marcia and his guests. Although his name gives him a clearer public identity, his anxiety during the dinner party shows how easily constructed identities can fall apart. Through these contrasting characters, Jackson suggests that unnamed characters are often trapped in uncertainty and transition, while named characters possess greater social stability, even if that stability is ultimately fragile.*

Topic sentence options:

- While some of Jackson's characters are unnamed to reflect their shifting sense of themselves, the naming of other characters reflects their individual sense of identity.
- By withholding names from certain protagonists, Jackson emphasises their uncertain sense of self, in contrast to named characters whose identities appear more firmly constructed.
- Many of Jackson's characters have names that reflect their role rather than their sense of individuality, while other characters remain unnamed, representing their inner discontent.

- Jackson often presents unnamed protagonists as psychologically uncertain figures, while named characters appear to possess greater social and personal stability.
- In many of Jackson's stories, anonymity reflects an unstable or transitional identity, whereas named characters are characterised by a stronger sense of certainty and control.

Evidence: 'The Daemon Lover': 'Anxiously she pulled through the dresses in the closet'; she 'hesitated until a door at the end opened'; 'suddenly horribly aware of her over-young print dress'; 'There's more than you think when you look at me.' 'Like Mother Used to Make': 'did everything in small, quick movements'; 'He had always been partial to yellows and browns'; 'It pleased him to have only one key to his home'; 'I like things this way.'

Paragraph frame: *In [story title], the unnamed/named character…; The character's [lack of a name / full name] reflects…; As [character]…, Jackson suggests…; Jackson develops this idea through…; However, in [story title]…; Although [character] appears…, Jackson reveals…; Through these contrasting characters, Jackson suggests…*

Windows and Doors

In Jackson's stories windows are highly symbolic: when characters look out of them, they are often thinking about a different life they could have lived.

- 'The Daemon Lover': 'She went to the window and saw that it was undeniably a fine day. It occurred to her that perhaps she ought not to wear the blue silk dress; it was too plain, almost severe, and she wanted to be soft, feminine.'
- 'Like Mother Used to Make': 'The window had been open all day and papers had blown wildly around the floor. David closed the window, hesitated over the papers, and then moved away quickly.'
- 'The Villager': 'The first thing Miss Clarence did was go to the window… far off to the left, a high building crowned with flower gardens. Someday I'll live there, she thought.'
- 'The Witch': 'The little boy was looking out the window… "I saw a witch," he said.'

In each, a character is having one kind of experience in their own world while seeing, or avoiding, a different kind of experience through the window. Words to describe this: *certainty, escape, possibility, freedom, discipline, logical thinking, separation between worlds, wanting more from life, comfort, belonging, imagination, the divide between, longing, desire for change, seeing beyond ordinary life, emotional escape, new experiences, responsibility, domestic harmony, dreams, fantasy, another life, hope, discontent with ordinary life, different futures, order, control.*

Sentence starters: *Throughout her fiction, Jackson uses windows as symbols of…; In many of her stories, Jackson positions windows as a means of revealing…; Repeatedly, Jackson uses windows to emphasise…; Throughout Jackson's work, windows function as representations of…; In story after story, Jackson uses windows to draw attention to…; Jackson's recurring use of windows highlights…; Across her stories, windows act as portals into…; Jackson repeatedly depicts windows as…; In many of Jackson's stories, windows reveal…*

Doors. Her stories also feature many doors and locks. While windows symbolise *possible* different lives, doors represent *actual* ways to enter other lives or to shut other people out: the

door that never opens in 'The Daemon Lover', David's single key in 'Like Mother Used to Make', the doors Harris opens in 'The Villager'. Word bank: *new experiences, opportunities for change, the ability to enter, access to another life, emotional withdrawal, exclusion from, being shut out, a sense of rejection, feeling of isolation* (ideas); *seek, desire, realise, resist, hope for, yearn, imagine, believe* (what characters do); *desperation for, anxiety, protection, hidden feelings, vulnerability, exclusion, social isolation, optimism, faith in transformation* (feelings).

Social Judgement Across the Stories

One of the powerful forces oppressing Jackson's characters is the social judgement they all feel. Her protagonists spend a lot of energy worrying about what others will think.

- 'The Daemon Lover': 'Why don't I go to the police–you go to the police for a missing person. And then thought, What a fool I'd look like.' She is worried about looking foolish and being pitied.
- 'The Villager': 'He wandered over and opened the bathroom door; when he glanced in Miss Clarence winced.' She is worried that the dirty bathroom will be judged as hers.
- 'The Renegade': 'anyone would tell on a chicken-killing dog; but he doesn't have to be so pleased about it.' Mrs Walpole is worried that her neighbours are enjoying her humiliation.

The protagonists also judge others and themselves: the protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' judges her own appearance and apartment; David judges the clerks who don't recognise him; Miss Clarence judges the Robertses' housekeeping; Mrs Walpole judges her own failures against the 'country folk'. In comparison, many minor characters seem almost immune to judgement: the stranger in 'The Witch' doesn't care what the mother thinks; the Robertses leave their messy apartment open for others to see; the grocer and the other men in 'The Renegade' don't consider how the dog's owner feels.

Topic sentence options:

- In Jackson's stories, the protagonists often shape their behaviour based on how they think others will judge them.
- Jackson contrasts anxious protagonists with confident outsiders who ignore social expectations and judgement.
- Many of Jackson's protagonists become trapped by their awareness of how they appear to others.
- Throughout her collection, Jackson suggests that people who are unaffected by social judgement can appear threatening, strange or powerful.

Sentence starters: *In the story..., the protagonist...; Jackson uses the character of... to demonstrate how...; Jackson develops this idea in... through the character of...; This idea is evident in... where... | Their belief that '...' reveals...; ...'s decision to '...' highlights...; When they '...' it demonstrates...; In the scene where '...' Jackson evokes...; Their reaction to '...' demonstrates...; Jackson's description of '...' emphasises...; At the moment where they '...' the reader can see...; The reference to '...' reinforces... | This also reveals...; This further highlights...; This also demonstrates...; Through this, Jackson conveys...; As a result...; Furthermore...; Moreover...; In contrast...; However...*

Racism and Social Judgement

The racism in 'After You, My Dear Alphonse' and 'Flower Garden' is part of Jackson's larger concern with how social judgement shapes society. Racism controls not only its victims, like Mr Jones in 'Flower Garden', but also those who act with prejudice. Like any form of social judgement, it makes everyone unhappy.

- **Reasons for social judgement:** desire to maintain social status; fear of being judged by others; pressure to conform to community expectations; anxiety about losing belonging or respectability; need to feel morally or socially superior; acceptance of racist assumptions as 'normal'; desire to appear polite; pressure to behave like others; worry about offending people with social power.
- **Impacts of social judgement:** emotional hurt or humiliation; confusion about how to react; individuals become outsiders within the community; people hide their true thoughts and feelings; resistance to stereotypes; misunderstanding of relationships; reinforcement of the accepted social order; defensiveness and insecurity about being exposed as prejudiced.

Model paragraph: *How does racism affect the characters in Shirley Jackson's short stories?*

- **Topic sentence:** While social judgement of all kinds is present in her stories, Shirley Jackson explicitly depicts racism as one way of maintaining social order in society.
- **Introduce and analyse an example:** The story 'After You, My Dear Alphonse' presents Mrs Wilson's racism towards her son's African-American friend, Boyd, as stemming from her need to position Boyd and his family as poor and working class in order to confirm her own identity as a superior middle-class white person. When Boyd resists Mrs Wilson's racist assumptions, such as her expectation that he 'will eat anything', she is left 'disappointed' because her belief that all people of colour must conform to certain stereotypes has been proven wrong.
- **Link to a further example:** However, while Boyd is able to withstand the controlling force of racism in 'After You, My Dear Alphonse', the same is not true of the victim of social judgement in 'Flower Garden'.
- **Introduce and analyse an example from a second story:** In this story, the white Mrs MacLane unwittingly transgresses the unspoken racist attitudes of the locals and hires an African-American gardener. This results in her ostracism, and Mrs MacLane asks her one-time friend 'what on earth is gone wrong?' Mrs Winning is motivated by her recurrent thought that 'something bad has happened' and that she is losing her own privileged place within the small community by associating with Mrs MacLane. At the end of the story, Mrs MacLane's garden is damaged by a broken branch, symbolising how social judgement and exclusion have broken her dream of a beautiful and fulfilled country life.
- **Synthesising sentence:** Through these two stories, Jackson reveals how racism operates as a powerful controlling force within society, dictating the actions of both perpetrators and victims.

Elizabeth and Clara: Confidence and Uncertainty

In many ways Elizabeth and Clara seem completely different: Elizabeth is determined and decisive, while Clara floats through her story in a kind of delirium. Adjectives to sort into 'Elizabeth', 'Clara' or 'both': *anxious, decisive, authoritative, insecure, uneasy, unstable, conflicted, grounded, confident, timid, principled, unsettled, assured, self-conscious, determined, steadfast*.

Sentence frames: *While at first glance Elizabeth appears… compared with Clara from 'The Tooth', who is more…, underneath they are both…; Even though Elizabeth behaves in a… manner when she…, she is also… because…; Although Clara seems… because she…, she also demonstrates that she can be… when she…*

Analyses of protagonists to match to characters (one analysis may suit more than one character):

- beneath a confident exterior, the character's self-perception remains surprisingly fragile and dependent on social validation;
- appears tentative and directionless in the beginning, but gradually develops a firmer understanding of themselves;
- presents an assured and carefully constructed identity that resists external scrutiny;
- confidence is not innate but carefully performed in order to conceal deep anxieties;
- deeply uncertain, drifting between competing versions of herself without ever fully committing to one;
- oscillates between confidence and self-doubt, never fully inhabiting either state;
- begins the story with absolute conviction, yet ends it isolated, confused and uncertain of her own identity;
- idealised visions of herself reflect a desperate desire for certainty and control;
- projects confidence because she unquestioningly conforms to social expectations;
- attachment to familiar domestic spaces reveals her need for stability and reassurance.

Characters to match: the protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover', David ('Like Mother Used to Make'), Miss Clarence ('The Villager'), Mrs Walpole ('The Renegade'), Mrs Wilson ('After You, My Dear Alphonse'), the mother in 'Charles', Mrs Winning ('Flower Garden'), Elizabeth, Mrs Tylor ('Of Course'), Clara ('The Tooth'). Then place every protagonist on a spectrum from *sure of themselves* to *uncertain*, once for the beginning of their story and once for the end.

Practice topic: *In the world of Shirley Jackson, identity is constructed in response to the demands of society. Discuss.*

Organising Evidence for Essays

For each key idea, collect evidence from three or four stories: the characters, their feelings and actions, and the quotes and symbols that show the idea. Re-read the summary of the idea in the Key Vocabulary notes, and use the annotation guides in the Story Study Guides to find stories and symbols that fit.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

Topic: *Jackson's stories are tales of exclusion and isolation. Discuss.*

- **Topic sentence:** Many of Jackson's protagonists experience profound isolation because they struggle to fit society's expectations of normality.
- **Initial examples from one story:** In [story], Jackson shows how people are excluded when…; Jackson emphasises this idea by…; This exclusion leads to…
- **Link:** In [story], Jackson presents another kind of social exclusion, when…
- **Further examples from another story:** This story explores… and…; Through [character]'s experience of…, Jackson…
- **Synthesising sentence:** Together, these stories suggest that…

A second topic sentence to try: *Jackson's stories also suggest that people often exclude others in order to protect their own sense of security and belonging.*

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

How does Jackson portray the inner frustration of ordinary lives? Brainstorm words for 'inner frustration' and 'ordinary lives', then choose a sub-idea:

- Many of Jackson's characters feel trapped by ordinary life.
- The stifling effects of family expectations lead to quiet dissatisfaction.
- Social expectations can leave people living with unmet expectations.
- Beneath everyday appearances lies deep emotional disappointment.
- For many characters, ordinary life brings frustration and the sense of unmet potential.
- Unable to change their circumstances, Jackson's characters often long for something more.
- Insecurity and inner grievances quietly shape many of Jackson's protagonists.
- Through everyday routines and settings, Jackson reveals hidden despair.

Dissatisfaction in Jackson's stories is both self-created and socially imposed. Discuss. Sub-ideas:

- Jackson's world is one of dissatisfaction and disillusionment.
- For Jackson's protagonists, unhappiness is rooted in their own insecurities.
- In the world of Jackson's short stories, discontent is fuelled by unrealistic expectations.
- Beyond their own choices, many characters are constrained by the limitations of the community.
- Jackson explores the tension between individual desires and social conformity.
- Unable to trust others, or their own judgement, Jackson's protagonists are trapped in unhappiness.
- Jackson reveals a world populated by those who form unhappy identities reinforced by society.

- Although they imagine themselves judged by others, Jackson's characters are victims of their own self-censorship.

Unexpected Events

Jackson's stories depict moments when the safety of everyday life becomes threatening. Discuss. This topic has two parts: everyday life is routine and safe; changes to routine and convention can reveal dangers. Brainstorm vocabulary and examples for 'safety of everyday life' and 'threatening ideas', then write one paragraph: in the first half, show how Jackson establishes a 'safe world'; in the second, how she 'threatens' it.

In Jackson's stories, ordinary life is both predictable and fragile. Here the focus is less on the unexpected events themselves than on what they reveal about how easily the structures of everyday life can be broken. Brainstorm 'predictable' against 'fragile', then write a paragraph responding to each part.

The Violence Beneath a Civilised Society

An essay process: circle key words in the topic; brainstorm alternative vocabulary; refer back to the stories and your notes to brainstorm examples; sort examples into three or four groups as the basis for body paragraphs; plan the topic sentence for each group; write the essay. Try it on:

- Politeness in Jackson's short stories often masks something far more sinister. To what extent do you agree?
- In Jackson's stories, violence emerges most shockingly from everyday life. Discuss.
- Jackson's stories reveal darkness beneath respectable appearances. Discuss.
- Jackson's stories suggest that ordinary social settings can conceal disturbing cruelty. Discuss.

Quote Banks

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘She was not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘There was nothing to eat in the apartment.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘In the drugstore she found that there was nothing she wanted to eat.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘Anxiously, she pulled through the dresses in the closet.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: She was ‘suddenly horribly aware of her over-young print dress.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘There’s more than you think when you look at me.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘all this coffee… no real breakfast.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: She ‘worried unnecessarily, at the window, over whether it would be a fine day.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: The blue silk dress was ‘too plain, almost severe, and she wanted to be soft, feminine.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘It was very early in the year for a print dress.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: Her make-up ‘was another delicate balance between looking as well as possible, and deceiving as little.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: The skirt looked made ‘for someone who would run freely, dance, swing it with her hips when she walked.’

> *The Villager*: ‘She had come to New York from a small town upstate because she wanted to be a dancer.’

> *The Villager*: ‘She could see only dirty roofs and, far off to the left, a high building crowned with flower gardens.’

> *Flower Garden*: Mrs Winning: ‘This dreary old place.’

> *Flower Garden*: Mrs Winning: 'It seems as though spring would never come. I get so tired of the cold.'

> *Elizabeth*: 'Just before the alarm went off she was lying in a hot sunny garden'; when she woke, 'it was raining.'

> *The Villager*: Miss Clarence tells herself she has 'a good job' and lives 'better than she would have in her home town.'

> *The Villager*: 'Someday I'll live there, she thought.'

> *The Villager*: 'Her shoulders ached.'

> *The Tooth*: Jim describes 'the waves ringing on the shore like bells' and 'nothing to do all day but lie under the trees.'

> *The Tooth*: Jim: 'The grass is so green and so soft.'

> *The Tooth*: 'Her hand in Jim's and her hair down on her shoulders, she ran barefoot through hot sand.'

> *Elizabeth*: 'I wish I'd been a blonde' – *her thought at the mirror*.

> *Elizabeth*: 'the ugly morning noises of people stirring'

> *Elizabeth*: 'something wonderful would happen to change her whole life'

> *The Tooth*: Her tooth 'seemed now the only part of her to have any identity.'

> *The Tooth*: 'you'd think my own face would know me' – *Clara's thoughts at the mirror*.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

> *The Daemon Lover*: 'She looked down and the boy grinned insolently at her.'

> *The Daemon Lover*: 'He said, "I hope you find your young man," and gave it a nasty sound.'

> *The Daemon Lover*: 'No matter how often or how firmly she knocked, no one ever came to the door.'

Like Mother Used to Make: Mr. Harris 'looked suspiciously at David.'

Like Mother Used to Make: The clerk 'looked past David at the next customer'; David thinks 'you'd think they'd know me well enough to be more courteous.'

Flower Garden: The townspeople advise Mrs Winning to talk to Mrs MacLane 'about that colored man.'

Flower Garden: 'Children will call names... There's not much you can do.'

Flower Garden: Mrs Winning thinks: 'pretty soon they'll stop coming to me first, they'll tell someone else to speak to me.'

Flower Garden: Mrs Winning 'swung around without speaking and started, with great dignity, back up the hill toward the old Winning house.'

Of Course: Mrs Harris: 'It means such a lot to have really thoughtful neighbors.'

Of Course: Mrs Tylor: 'There's something so nice about congenial people right next door.'

The Daemon Lover: 'Why don't I go to the police... What a fool I'd look like.'

The Villager: 'He wandered over and opened the bathroom door; when he glanced in Miss Clarence winced.'

The Villager: Miss Clarence judges the absent Mrs Roberts: 'she doesn't even make coffee in the morning.'

The Renegade: 'Anyone would tell on a chicken-killing dog; but he doesn't have to be so pleased about it.'

After You, My Dear Alphonse: Mrs Wilson: 'Boyd will eat anything.'

After You, My Dear Alphonse: Mrs Wilson: 'Don't think I'm angry, Boyd. I'm just disappointed in you.'

Flower Garden: The two Mrs Winnings 'had grown to look a good deal alike'; 'uncounted Winning children had played with almost identical toys.'

Flower Garden: Mrs Winning: 'Something bad has happened, somehow people think

> they know something about me that they won't say.'

> *Flower Garden*: Mrs MacLane: 'What on earth is gone wrong?'

> *Of Course*: Mrs Tylor 'was far too polite to go' out and stare at her new neighbours.

> *Of Course*: 'A nice-looking tan suit… Nice people, obviously.'

> *Of Course*: 'Carol shut her mouth obstinately and the little boy edged behind his mother.'

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: Mrs Wilson: 'Does he…work?'

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: 'Mrs. Wilson restrained an impulse to pat Boyd on the head.'

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: Mrs Wilson: 'There are many little boys like you, Boyd, who would be very grateful for the clothes someone was kind enough to give them.'

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: Boyd: 'But I have plenty of clothes, thank you'

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: Johnny: 'She's screwy sometimes.' Boyd: 'So's mine.'

> *Charles*: 'None of them looked to me haggard enough.' – *the mother, scanning the other mothers.*

> *Elizabeth*: 'Dried-up old maid' – *a woman on the bus.*

> *Elizabeth*: 'there was no one around to tell Elizabeth Style'

> *The Renegade*: 'The voice sounded satisfied now; Mrs. Walpole had been cornered.'

> *The Renegade*: Mr White: 'Guess you're not going to have any more dog.'

Identity and Gender

> *Like Mother Used to Make*: 'David Turner, who did everything in small quick movements'

> *Like Mother Used to Make*: 'The neat small table and four careful chairs.'

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘It pleased him to have only one key to his home.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘He had chosen a sedate, pretty pattern.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘I like things this way.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘Marcia arrived with a shout and fresh air and disorder.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘She was a tall handsome girl with a loud voice.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘Marcia was always hungry.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘The window had been open all day and papers had blown wildly around the floor.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘He had always been partial to yellows and browns.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘Marcia’s home was bare and at random.’

The Villager: Harris: ‘What I need is a wife.’

Charles: Laurie has become ‘a long-trousered, swaggering character.’

Charles: The teacher: ‘We had a little trouble adjusting, the first week or so.’

Flower Garden: Mrs MacLane ‘had some money in her own name.’

After You, My Dear Alphonse: Johnny: ‘Boyd’s father doesn’t have to… He’s a foreman.’

After You, My Dear Alphonse: Johnny: ‘Why should she?… You don’t work.’

Charles: Laurie: ‘Hi, Pop, y’old dust mop.’

Elizabeth: ‘Because they were not married, Robbie was reluctant to take her anywhere where he might be embarrassed by her presence.’

The Tooth: Clara: ‘Leave a note telling him we want eggs.’ – *her last words to her husband.*

The Tooth: Her husband: ‘You had a toothache on our honeymoon’

The Renegade: Lady welcomes the children ‘as though they were the aliens and she the native to the house.’

Unexpected Events and Strangers

The Witch: ‘The little boy was looking out the window’; then he tells his mother, ‘I saw a witch.’

The Witch: ‘Did you cut her all in pieces?’ the little boy asked breathlessly.

The Witch: The stranger: ‘I pinched her and I pinched her until she was dead… I cut off her head and her hands’

The Witch: ‘With his lollipop he went back to his own seat, and settled himself to look out the window again. “Prob’ly he was a witch.” ‘

Of Course: Mrs Tylor ‘recognized finally the faint nervous feeling that was tagging her; it was the way she felt when she was irrevocably connected with something dangerously out of control.’

Charles: ‘Charles? We don’t have any Charles in the kindergarten.’

The Witch: Strangers tell the boy he is ‘a fine big fellow’; ‘These comments annoyed the little boy.’

The Witch: The boy gives his age: ‘Twenty-six. Eight hunnerd and forty eighty’; his name: ‘Mr. Jesus.’

The Witch: The baby is ‘strapped securely to the seat.’

The Witch: The mother: ‘He was just teasing… Just teasing.’

Charles: The mother: ‘I suppose this time it’s Charles’s influence.’

Charles: The father: ‘Bound to be people like Charles in the world. Might as well meet them now as later.’

The Tooth: ‘My name is Jim,’ the strange man said.

> *The Tooth*: Jim ‘held out a handful of pearls.’

The Violence Beneath a Civilised Society

> *The Lottery*: ‘The morning of June 27th was clear and sunny, with the fresh warmth of a full-summer day.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘Bobby Martin had already stuffed his pockets full of stones.’

> *The Lottery*: Mrs Hutchinson: ‘Clean forgot what day it was.’

> *The Lottery*: Mrs Hutchinson: ‘Wouldn’t have me leave m’dishes in the sink, now, would you, Joe?’

> *The Lottery*: Mrs Hutchinson: ‘Get up there, Bill.’

> *The Lottery*: Old Man Warner: ‘Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon.’

> *The Lottery*: Old Man Warner: ‘There’s always been a lottery.’

> *The Lottery*: Mrs Hutchinson: ‘You didn’t give him time enough to take any paper he wanted. I saw you. It wasn’t fair!’

> *The Lottery*: Bill Hutchinson: ‘Shut up, Tessie.’

> *The Lottery*: Mrs Hutchinson: ‘I think we ought to start over.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘Although the villagers had forgotten the ritual and lost the original black box, they still remembered to use stones.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘Mrs. Delacroix selected a stone so large she had to pick it up with both hands.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘Come on,’ she said. ‘Hurry up.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘Come on, come on, everyone.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘It isn’t fair, it isn’t right,’ Mrs. Hutchinson screamed, and then they were upon her.

> *The Renegade*: ‘The spikes cut her head off.’

> *The Renegade*: ‘They both began to laugh…’

> *The Renegade*: ‘Mrs. Walpole closed her eyes, suddenly feeling the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat.’

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: Johnny: ‘Dead Japanese… We stand them in the ground and run over them with tanks.’

> *Charles*: Laurie: ‘Today Charles hit the teacher.’

> *Charles*: ‘Charles bounced a see-saw on to the head of a little girl and made her bleed’

> *Elizabeth*: ‘I’m afraid Mr. Shax didn’t have courage enough to tell you’ – *Elizabeth, dismissing Daphne.*

> *The Renegade*: ‘the murderous brutality a pretty dog like Lady could keep so well hidden in their home’

> *The Renegade*: The grocer: ‘Scratch his eyes out… He wouldn’t ever be able to see another chicken.’

Character Quote Bank

Every quotation below has been checked word for word against the text of the collection. Quotations are grouped by story and by character, with a note on where each one comes from. Where a character speaks, the words are theirs; where the line is narration or a character's thoughts, the note says so.

'The Daemon Lover'

The protagonist (unnamed, thirty-four)

> 'Anne, by the time you get this I will be married.' – *the letter to her sister, which she tears up.*

> She 'was not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment.' – *narration, at two minutes past ten.*

> She 'tried to think of Jamie and could not see his face clearly, or hear his voice.' – *narration, while waiting.*

> 'Please don't make any mistake... I'm afraid you don't understand.' – *to the superintendent's wife, in a voice 'with thirty-four years of accumulated pride'.*

> 'Why don't I go to the police... What a fool I'd look like.' – *her thoughts, deciding against it.*

Jamie Harris (seen only through others)

> 'He's rather tall, and fair. He wears a blue suit very often. He's a writer.' – *her description of him.*

> 'This is a big day for me, kid' – *the words the boy says Jamie spoke to him.*

The strangers

> 'You got the wrong house, lady' and, more quietly, 'or the wrong guy' – *the superintendent, before he and his wife laugh.*

> 'Now how many men in blue suits go past here every day, lady?' – *the delicatessen man.*

> 'I hope you find your young man' – *the florist, who 'gave it a nasty sound'.*

> 'You gonna divorce him, missus? You got something on him?' – *the boy, running off with*

> *her dollar*.

‘Like Mother Used to Make’

David Turner

> ‘David Turner, who did everything in small quick movements’ – *the opening line*.

> ‘it pleased him to have only one key to his home, and that safely in his own pocket’ – *narration*.

> ‘I like things this way.’ – *to Marcia, over dinner*.

> ‘You ought to keep your home neater.’ – *to Marcia*.

> ‘Guess I better be getting along, Marcia.’ – *instead of telling Mr Harris the truth*.

> ‘Thanks for a simply wonderful dinner, Marcia’ – *leaving his own apartment*.

Marcia

> ‘I didn’t forget, Davie, I’m just late as usual. What’s for dinner?’ – *arriving*.

> ‘Someone should teach me, I guess.’ – *on keeping house*.

> ‘I haven’t made but two, three pies before’ – *claiming David’s pie in front of Mr Harris*.

> ‘I don’t think Davie liked it much… I think it was too sour for him.’ – *said ‘wickedly’*.

> ‘Don’t forget your key.’ – *handing David the key to her apartment*.

Mr Harris

> ‘I just thought I’d stop by.’ – *arriving uninvited*.

> ‘I like a sour pie… A cherry pie’s got to be sour.’ – *as he ‘looked suspiciously at David’*.

‘The Villager’

Miss Hilda Clarence

> Her novel she ‘had read enthusiastically up to page fifty and only carried now for effect’ –

> *narration.*

> In letters home she 'referred to herself as a "Village die-hard."' – *narration.*

> 'Someday I'll live there, she thought' – *looking at a building 'crowned with flower gardens'.*

> 'Not as easy as it used to be, she thought, it catches you in the shoulders.' – *trying the dancer's pose.*

> 'Dancer,' she said. – *answering Harris's question.*

> 'Artie's going to Paris' – *taking on Mrs Roberts's life.*

> 'Her shoulders ached.' – *the final line.*

Harris

> 'Or, rather, I hope to write' – *introducing himself.*

> 'This place is certainly nicer than mine… Mine's a hole in the wall.'

> 'What I need is a wife.'

'The Witch'

Johnny, the little boy

> 'I saw a witch… There was a big old ugly old bad old witch outside.' – *to his mother.*

> 'I'm a man already' – *to the stranger.*

> 'Mr. Jesus' – *when the stranger asks his name.*

> 'Did you cut her all in pieces?' – *asked 'breathlessly'.*

> 'Prob'ly he was a witch.' – *the final line.*

The stranger

> 'Hello yourself, son.' – *his first words.*

> ‘All men smoke cigars… Someday you’ll smoke a cigar, too.’

> ‘I bought her a rocking-horse and a doll and a million lollipops’ – *the start of his story about his sister.*

> ‘Did I frighten you?’ – *to the mother, before he and the boy laugh.*

The mother

> ‘Not much longer now’ – *her answer ‘each time’ the boy asks how far they have to go.*

> ‘Just what do you think you’re doing?… Get out of here.’ – *to the stranger.*

> ‘He was just teasing… Just teasing.’ – *to Johnny.*

> ‘You sit still and be a good boy. You may have another lollipop.’

‘The Renegade’

Mrs Walpole

> ‘That’s perfectly ridiculous’ – *on the phone, told her dog kills chickens.*

> ‘I just can’t believe it of Lady. She’s so gentle.’

> ‘anyone would tell on a chicken-killing dog; but he doesn’t have to be so pleased about it’ – *her thoughts about Mr White.*

> ‘But how did he feel about you?… Did he ever like you again?’ – *to the grocer, about his father’s dog.*

> ‘feeling the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat’ – *the final line.*

The townspeople

> ‘He’s been killing my chickens.’ – *the caller; ‘The voice sounded satisfied now; Mrs. Walpole had been cornered.’*

> ‘You’ll have to do something about the dog.’ – *the caller.*

> ‘Guess you’re not going to have any more dog.’ – *Mr White, grinning*.

> ‘You get a dead chicken and tie it around the dog’s neck’ – *Mr White*.

> ‘Sure… Shoot him.’ – *the man at the grocery, asked if the dog can be cured*.

> ‘Scratch his eyes out… He wouldn’t ever be able to see another chicken.’ – *the grocer*.

Jack and Judy (the twins)

> ‘She’s going to get shot.’ – *Judy*.

> ‘Then we put this real sharp spiky collar around your neck’ – *Jack, before he ‘kissed the top of her head’*.

> ‘The spikes cut her head off’ – *Jack*.

> ‘They both began to laugh’ – *narration, as Lady pants ‘as though she were laughing too’*.

‘Charles’

Laurie

> ‘Isn’t anybody here?’ – *coming home from his first day*.

> ‘I didn’t learn nothing’ – *to his father*.

> ‘Today Charles hit the teacher.’ – *said as he ‘grinned enormously’*.

> ‘Look at my thumb. Gee, you’re dumb.’ – *to his father*.

> ‘Hi, Pop, y’old dust mop.’

Laurie’s mother (the narrator)

> ‘a long-trousered, swaggering character who forgot to stop at the corner and wave good-bye to me’ – *on Laurie’s first morning*.

> ‘this Charles boy sounds like such a bad influence’ – *to her husband*.

> ‘I wanted passionately to meet Charles’s mother’ – *narration*.

> ‘I suppose this time it’s Charles’s influence.’ – *to the teacher*.

Laurie’s father and the teacher

> ‘Bound to be people like Charles in the world. Might as well meet them now as later.’ – *Laurie’s father*.

> ‘We had a little trouble adjusting, the first week or so… but now he’s a fine little helper. With occasional lapses, of course.’ – *the teacher, about Laurie*.

> ‘We don’t have any Charles in the kindergarten.’ – *the teacher*.

‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’

Mrs Wilson

> ‘Boyd will eat anything.’

> ‘Boyd wants to grow up and be a big strong man so he can work hard’

> ‘Does he…work?’ – *about Boyd’s father, after she ‘hesitated’*.

> She ‘restrained an impulse to pat Boyd on the head.’ – *narration*.

> ‘There are many little boys like you, Boyd, who would be very grateful for the clothes someone was kind enough to give them.’ – *taking the gingerbread away*.

> ‘Don’t think I’m angry, Boyd. I’m just disappointed in you, that’s all.’

Boyd

> ‘How do you do, Mrs. Wilson?’

> ‘My father eats anything he wants to’

> ‘But I have plenty of clothes, thank you’ – *refusing the bundle*.

> ‘Is your mother still mad?’ – *asked ‘in a low voice’*.

Johnny

> ‘Dead Japanese… We stand them in the ground and run over them with tanks.’ – *explaining the wood.*

> ‘Boyd’s father doesn’t have to… He’s a foreman.’

> ‘Why should she?… You don’t work.’ – *to his mother, about Boyd’s mother.*

> ‘She’s screwy sometimes.’ (Boyd: ‘So’s mine.’)

‘Flower Garden’

Young Mrs Winning (Helen)

> ‘It seems as though spring would never come… I get so tired of the cold.’ – *the opening.*

> ‘This could have been mine, she was thinking’ – *in the cottage.*

> ‘This dreary old place’ – *of the Winning house.*

> ‘Children will call names… There’s not much you can do.’ – *after Howard’s racist name-calling.*

> ‘You won’t have him working here past today, will you?’ – *about Mr Jones.*

> ‘pretty soon they’ll stop coming to me first, they’ll tell someone else to speak to me’ – *her thoughts.*

> ‘I sound exactly like Mother Winning, and realized, I’m enjoying this’ – *her thoughts, as Mrs MacLane asks for help.*

> ‘The nerve of her, trying to blame the colored folks.’ – *her thoughts.*

> She ‘swung around without speaking and started, with great dignity, back up the hill toward the old Winning house.’ – *the final line.*

Mrs MacLane

> ‘I love gardens.’

> ‘I don’t think I’ve ever been so happy.’

> ‘Go tell that boy you’re sorry’ – *to Davey*.

> ‘What I wanted to ask you is, what on earth is gone wrong?’

> ‘Are you sure it isn’t because of Mr. Jones working here?’

> ‘Do you think I ought to give it up, Mr. Jones? Go back to the city where I’ll never have to see another garden?’

> ‘Leave it for the next people to move!’

The town

> ‘Not that kind of help’ – *the elder Mrs Winning*.

> ‘you ought to talk to her about that colored man working there’ – *the elder Mrs Winning*.

> ‘He’s there every blessed day… And working out there without his shirt on.’ – *the elder Mrs Winning*.

> ‘Where’s that dressed-up friend of yours get to?’ – *Mrs Harris*.

> ‘I just thought you might mind if he didn’t come.’ – *Mrs Burton, about Davey and the birthday party*.

‘Elizabeth’

Elizabeth Style

> ‘Just before the alarm went off she was lying in a hot sunny garden’ – *the opening*.

> ‘the ugly morning noises of people stirring’ – *narration*.

> ‘I wish I’d been a blonde’ – *her thought at the mirror*.

> ‘Is he trying in his own heavy-handed fashion to beautify the office?’ – *her thoughts about Daphne’s hiring*.

> ‘good old Harris, he never has a chance if you talk fast’ – *her thoughts after the phone call*.

> ‘I’m afraid Mr. Shax didn’t have courage enough to tell you’ – *dismissing Daphne.*

> ‘something wonderful would happen to change her whole life’ – *narration, before Harris arrives.*

> ‘while she was planning her new life she forgot Jim Harris, his heavy face, his thin voice’ – *narration.*

Others

> ‘Dried-up old maid’ – *a woman on the bus.*

> ‘there was no one around to tell Elizabeth Style’ – *narration, on her arrival in New York at twenty.*

> ‘Mr. Shax didn’t tell me anything’ – *Daphne Hill.*

> ‘A suit like yours?’ – *Daphne, looking Elizabeth up and down.*

‘The Tooth’

Clara Spencer

> ‘I feel so funny’ – *to her husband at the bus.*

> ‘Milkman… Leave a note telling him we want eggs.’ – *her last words to him.*

> Her tooth ‘seemed now the only part of her to have any identity.’ – *narration.*

> ‘you’d think my own face would know me’ – *her thoughts at the mirror.*

> ‘Clara… Clara?’ – *reading her own name on her barrette.*

> ‘her hand in Jim’s and her hair down on her shoulders, she ran barefoot through hot sand.’ – *the final line.*

Her husband and Jim

> ‘You had a toothache on our honeymoon’ – *her husband, ‘accusingly’.*

> ‘It’s only a toothache.’ – *her husband.*

> ‘My name is Jim’ – *the stranger*.

> ‘Even farther than Samarkand… and the waves ringing on the shore like bells.’ – *Jim*.

> ‘The sand is so white it looks like snow’ – *Jim*.

> ‘The grass is so green and so soft’ – *Jim, on the escalator*.

‘Of Course’

Mrs Tylor

> ‘Nice people, obviously.’ – *her judgement from a tan suit*.

> ‘There’s something so nice about congenial people right next door.’

> ‘Of course… No radio.’

> ‘feeling as though she had been saying nothing else all morning’ – *narration*.

> ‘I’ll go with you, dear.’ – *the final line, agreeing to take Carol to the movies*.

Mrs Harris

> ‘James does not go to movies.’

> ‘Mr. Harris… feels that movies are intellectually retarding.’

> ‘Mr. Harris just feels that the newspapers are a mass degradation of taste.’

> ‘It’s terribly hard for people to understand the desire for a really peaceful life.’

> ‘You’ll be thinking my husband is crazy.’

> ‘Pre-Elizabethan, of course.’ – *the only plays her husband reads*.

‘The Lottery’

Tessie Hutchinson

> ‘Clean forgot what day it was’ – *arriving late*.

> ‘Wouldn’t have me leave m’dishes in the sink, now, would you, Joe?’

> ‘Get up there, Bill.’

> ‘You didn’t give him time enough to take any paper he wanted. I saw you. It wasn’t fair!’

> ‘There’s Don and Eva… Make them take their chance!’ – *trying to add her married daughter’s household.*

> ‘It isn’t fair, it isn’t right’ – *her last words.*

Mr Summers and Mr Graves

> People ‘were sorry for him, because he had no children and his wife was a scold.’ – *narration, on Mr Summers.*

> ‘Little late today, folks.’ – *Mr Summers.*

> ‘Take your time, son.’ – *Mr Summers, to the Watson boy.*

> ‘Daughters draw with their husbands’ families, Tessie’ – *Mr Summers.*

> ‘Let’s finish quickly.’ – *Mr Summers, once Tessie’s paper is shown.*

> ‘Harry, you help little Dave.’ – *Mr Summers; Mr Graves holds the child’s slip.*

Old Man Warner

> ‘Pack of crazy fools’ – *on villages giving up the lottery.*

> ‘Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon.’

> ‘There’s always been a lottery’

> ‘Seventy-seventh year I been in the lottery’

> ‘Come on, come on, everyone.’

The other villagers

> ‘Shut up, Tessie.’ – *Bill Hutchinson, who later ‘forced the slip of paper out of her hand’.*

> ‘Be a good sport, Tessie’ – *Mrs Delacroix.*

> ‘All of us took the same chance.’ – *Mrs Graves.*

> Mrs Delacroix ‘selected a stone so large she had to pick it up with both hands’ – *narration.*

> ‘I can’t run at all. You’ll have to go ahead and I’ll catch up with you.’ – *Mrs Dunbar.*

> ‘Some places have already quit lotteries’ – *Mrs Adams; at the end, ‘Steve Adams was in the front of the crowd’.*

Theme Analysis

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

Jackson's protagonists are frequently discontented. The woman in 'The Daemon Lover' suffers from deep-seated dissatisfaction, anxiety about her appearance and ageing, and insecurity about her desirability; she hopes marriage will let her reinvent herself. Miss Clarence in 'The Villager' disguises her disappointment that she never became a dancer. Elizabeth Style pins her hopes on Jim Harris. Clara Spencer escapes her grey life entirely, at the cost of her identity.

Jackson suggests that these characters' unhappiness is shaped both by society and by themselves. Social expectations about marriage, success and femininity set the standards they fail to meet, but their own fantasies of another life deepen their dissatisfaction. As one useful interpretation puts it, the protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' intensifies her own unhappiness through her thoughts, choices and actions, while the happiness of others accentuates her dissatisfaction.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

Jackson's communities decide who belongs. People who challenge social expectations are judged, excluded or punished: Mrs MacLane for employing Mr Jones, Mrs Walpole for her uncontrolled dog, David for failing to be the right kind of man. Insiders police the boundaries out of fear of becoming outsiders themselves: Mrs Winning abandons her friend because she is anxious about losing belonging and respectability.

Useful vocabulary: *conformity, gatekeepers, ostracise, marginalise, alienated, exclusionary, respectability, social status*.

Unexpected Events Expose Our Struggles

A stranger arrives, a fiancé disappears, a dog kills chickens, a man on a train tells a story. In each case, the disruption exposes problems that already existed beneath the surface: Miss Clarence's disappointment, David's passivity, Mrs Walpole's fear of her neighbours, the mother's inability to control what her son learns. James Harris, who appears in story after story, embodies this idea: he enters characters' lives unexpectedly and reveals the gap between how they see themselves and how others see them.

Useful vocabulary: *catalyst, disruption, destabilise, unravel, expose, vulnerability*.

The Violence and Cruelty Beneath a Civilised Society

Physical violence features in only a few stories ('The Witch', 'The Renegade', 'The Lottery'), so think of this idea as including cruelty, insensitivity, intolerance and lack of compassion. Jackson's violence is often:

- **Arbitrary** – based on chance rather than any fair reason, like the lottery's random selection;
- **Ritualised** – performed according to tradition, like the annual drawing;
- **Normalised** – treated as ordinary even when it is harmful, like the neighbours' advice in 'The Renegade';

- **Entrenched** – so established that it is difficult to change, like the racism of ‘Flower Garden’.

Jackson repeatedly shows that the most disturbing cruelty comes from ordinary, respectable people: friendly neighbours, polite mothers, children. Children both reveal the hidden prejudices of adults and occasionally resist them, highlighting the flaws in adult values.

Conformity and Tradition

Many stories show a chain of social pressure: society establishes rules about how people should behave; adults teach children what is normal; fear of punishment pressures people to conform; people come to accept the rules without questioning them; and harmful attitudes are passed from one generation to the next. In ‘The Lottery’, even little Davy Hutchinson is given pebbles.

Key Vocabulary for the Four Ideas

Jackson’s characters are a strange and varied lot, but her stories return again and again to a few central ideas. In the longer stories most of these ideas are present; in the shorter ones it is easier to see just one or two. Reading with these ideas in mind will help you read with purpose.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

Like people in the real world, Jackson’s characters feel judged by those around them, and they judge others. Many judgements rest on societal expectations about the appropriate way to behave, some tied to the era (women as good housekeepers, men as strong providers). Most of Jackson’s protagonists break with what is ‘accepted’ in some way, and feel uneasy about not fitting in and anxious about their choices. Many feel strongly that they should go along with the unwritten rules of dominant values.

- **Social judgement:** cultural, community, public, accepted, unwritten, expected, dominant, mainstream, collective; expectations, standards, conventions, behaviours, rules, pressures, values, attitudes, roles.
- **Exclusion:** alienation, isolation, marginalisation, ostracism, loneliness, separation, detachment, disconnection, lack of belonging.
- **Anxiety:** tension, uncertainty, dread, unease, insecurity, emotional turbulence, nervousness, agitation, concern.

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

Many protagonists feel insecure about their life choices or identity. Even characters who seem certain daydream about alternative lives or feel unhappy about some aspect of their lives. They often express insecurity by imagining different lifestyles, and they regularly look out of windows or through doorways while doing so. Another sign of self-doubt is choosing clothes and feeling that none of their outfits, belongings or homes are right.

- **Dissatisfaction:** discontent, frustration, restlessness, resentment, longing for more, lack of fulfilment, feeling trapped, disappointment, quiet despair.
- **Insecurity:** uncertainty, self-doubt, self-consciousness, lack of confidence, fear of judgement, feelings of inadequacy, social awkwardness, nervousness, hesitation.

- **Struggling with identity:** disconnection with self, role confusion, internal conflict, feelings of otherness, lack of self-assurance, uncertain of purpose, feelings of personal failure, yearning for validation.

Unexpected Events Expose Our Struggles

In every story there is an unexpected event, or the arrival of a stranger, that exposes the protagonist's inner struggles. Sometimes these events seem positive and make characters feel their lives will change for the better. At other times strange people and events make characters feel more vulnerable and unsure of themselves. Occasionally they help characters see that their own lives are worth keeping. Jackson's larger point is that surprises make us look at our own lives in a new light.

- **Unexpected events:** an unforeseen development, a sudden shift in perspective, a disruption to normality, an unpredictable turn of events, something at odds with convention, an event which is psychologically unsettling, an unprecedented change.
- **Unexpected encounters:** a crossing of paths, a fleeting exchange, an accidental meeting, a destabilising social encounter, a moment of unexpected human connection, a symbolic encounter with otherness, being drawn into a stranger's orbit.

The Violence Beneath a Civilised Society

Beneath the thin veneer of polite society lie violent thoughts and, often, violent actions. Sometimes violence is treated as an ordinary, expected part of life, such as putting down a dog that kills chickens. At other times it is disturbing and frightening, like a stranger telling a child a fantasy about killing his sister. Even stories without physical violence have characters expressing violent emotions or bullying others. Jackson is not condoning violence; she exposes it as a fundamental part of being human.

- **Violent thoughts and actions:** aggressive impulses, destructive behaviour, hostile actions, emotional volatility, eruptions of anger, acts of hostility, simmering resentment, sinister thoughts, impulsive acts of emotional aggression, hostility driven by insecurity, a surprising capacity for brutality.
- **Beneath a civilised veneer:** under the surface of respectability, behind a facade of civility, beneath an appearance of order, concealed by social refinement, hidden beneath cultivated manners, under a mask of normality, concealed by respectability, under the guise of civility, beneath the rituals of polite society, hidden behind outward conformity, obscured by the cultivated image of control.

Story and Theme Grid

Use this grid when you plan a Section A essay. Find the idea in the topic, read down the column, and choose three or four stories: usually one or two where the idea is central, supported by others where it is present. Every rating below is based on what happens in the story itself, and the evidence under the grid shows where to find it.

Key: •• = central to the story; • = present and usable; blank = not a strong choice for that idea.

Story	Insecurity	Judgement	Unexpected	Violence	Conformity	Gender	Children
'The Daemon Lover'	••	•	••	•	•	••	
'Like Mother Used to Make'	•	••	••		•	••	
'The Villager'	••	•	••			•	
'The Witch'			••	••	•		••
'The Renegade'	•	••	••	••	••	•	••
'Charles'		•	•	•			••
'After You, My Dear Alphonse'		••	•	•	••		••
'Flower Garden'	••	••	••	•	••	•	•
'Elizabeth'	••	•	••	•		•	
'The Tooth'	••		••			•	
'Of Course'		••	••		••	•	•
'The Lottery'		••	•	••	••	•	••

Column headings: *Insecurity* = insecurity and dissatisfaction; *Judgement* = social judgement and exclusion; *Unexpected* = unexpected events and strangers expose our struggles; *Violence* = violence and cruelty beneath a civilised society; *Conformity* = conformity and tradition; *Gender* = gender roles, marriage and the domestic sphere; *Children* = children and how they learn adult values.

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

Central: 'The Daemon Lover', 'The Villager', 'Flower Garden', 'Elizabeth', 'The Tooth'.

- 'The Daemon Lover': she 'was not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment', and pins her hopes on a marriage that never happens.
- 'The Villager': her novel was read 'up to page fifty and only carried now for effect'; the story ends, 'Her shoulders ached.'
- 'Flower Garden': Mrs Winning calls her home 'This dreary old place' and thinks of the cottage, 'This could have been mine'.
- 'Elizabeth': she believes 'something wonderful would happen to change her whole life'.

- ‘The Tooth’: Clara thinks, ‘you’d think my own face would know me’.
- **Present:** David’s need for order in ‘Like Mother Used to Make’; Mrs Walpole’s resentment of her routine in ‘The Renegade’.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

Central: ‘Like Mother Used to Make’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, ‘Flower Garden’, ‘Of Course’, ‘The Lottery’.

- ‘Like Mother Used to Make’: David is edged out of his own home, saying only ‘Guess I better be getting along, Marcia.’
- ‘The Renegade’: Mrs Walpole, a newcomer, thinks of Mr White, ‘anyone would tell on a chicken-killing dog; but he doesn’t have to be so pleased about it’.
- ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’: Mrs Wilson judges Boyd by race: ‘Boyd will eat anything.’
- ‘Flower Garden’: the elder Mrs Winning says ‘you ought to talk to her about that colored man working there’; young Mrs Winning thinks, ‘pretty soon they’ll stop coming to me first, they’ll tell someone else to speak to me.’
- ‘Of Course’: Mrs Tylor judges by appearances (‘Nice people, obviously’), then is judged in turn.
- ‘The Lottery’: when Tessie protests, the crowd replies, ‘Be a good sport, Tessie’ and ‘All of us took the same chance.’
- **Present:** the mocking strangers in ‘The Daemon Lover’; the mother scanning other mothers in ‘Charles’; the woman on the bus in ‘Elizabeth’ (‘Dried-up old maid’).

Unexpected Events and Strangers

Central: ‘The Daemon Lover’, ‘Like Mother Used to Make’, ‘The Villager’, ‘The Witch’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘Flower Garden’, ‘Elizabeth’, ‘The Tooth’, ‘Of Course’. Almost every story has one, so choose the stories where the disruption reveals the most.

- A man disappears: Jamie Harris in ‘The Daemon Lover’.
- A man arrives: Mr Harris in ‘Like Mother Used to Make’ (‘I just thought I’d stop by’) and Harris in ‘The Villager’ (‘You’re Mrs. Roberts?’).
- A stranger tells a story: the old man in ‘The Witch’ (‘shall I tell you about my little sister?’).
- A phone call: ‘He’s been killing my chickens’ in ‘The Renegade’.
- A newcomer: Mrs MacLane in ‘Flower Garden’; Daphne Hill in ‘Elizabeth’; the Harrises in ‘Of Course’.
- A guide: ‘My name is Jim,’ in ‘The Tooth’.
- **Present:** Boyd’s visit in ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, where each fact about his family overturns Mrs Wilson’s assumptions; the revelation in ‘Charles’ (‘We don’t have any Charles in the kindergarten’); the second drawing in ‘The Lottery’.

Violence and Cruelty Beneath a Civilised Society

Central: ‘The Witch’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘The Lottery’.

- ‘The Witch’: a pleasant elderly man in a blue suit says he ‘pinched her and I pinched her until she was dead’.
- ‘The Renegade’: the twins explain the spiked collar: ‘The spikes cut her head off.’
- ‘The Lottery’: ‘Although the villagers had forgotten the ritual and lost the original black box, they still remembered to use stones.’
- **Present** (cruelty rather than physical violence): the jeering strangers in ‘The Daemon Lover’; Laurie’s invented violence in ‘Charles’; the boys’ war game in ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’ (‘We stand them in the ground and run over them with tanks’); Howard’s racist name-calling and the town’s freezing-out of Mrs MacLane in ‘Flower Garden’; Elizabeth’s treatment of Daphne.

Conformity and Tradition

Central: ‘The Renegade’, ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, ‘Flower Garden’, ‘Of Course’, ‘The Lottery’.

- ‘The Lottery’: ‘There’s always been a lottery’; ‘no one liked to upset even as much tradition as was represented by the black box.’
- ‘Flower Garden’: after eleven years the two Mrs Winnings ‘had grown to look a good deal alike’; she is ‘officially a Winning’.
- ‘The Renegade’: the grocer insists, ‘Won’t do to have a dog going around killing chickens, Mrs. Walpole.’
- ‘Of Course’: Mrs Tylor keeps saying ‘Of course’, ‘feeling as though she had been saying nothing else all morning’.
- ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’: Mrs Wilson’s charity follows the assumptions of her society, not the facts in front of her.
- **Present:** the pressure to marry in ‘The Daemon Lover’; David’s surrender to politeness in ‘Like Mother Used to Make’; the mother’s lollipop rewards in ‘The Witch’.

Gender Roles, Marriage and the Domestic Sphere

Central: ‘The Daemon Lover’, ‘Like Mother Used to Make’.

- ‘The Daemon Lover’: she begins a letter, ‘Anne, by the time you get this I will be married.’
- ‘Like Mother Used to Make’: David’s pride in his home (‘it pleased him to have only one key to his home’) is taken over by Marcia, who claims the pie: ‘I haven’t made but two, three pies before’.
- **Present:** ‘The Villager’ (Harris: ‘What I need is a wife.’); ‘The Renegade’ (Mrs Walpole’s morning revolves around her husband and children); ‘Flower Garden’ (Mrs Harris: ‘Let that husband of yours do the housework for a change.’); ‘Elizabeth’ (‘Because they were not married, Robbie was reluctant to take her anywhere’); ‘The Tooth’ (Clara’s last instruction to her husband is about the milkman and eggs); ‘Of Course’ (the absent Mr Harris sets every rule); ‘The Lottery’ (‘Wife draws for her husband’).

Children and How They Learn Adult Values

Central: ‘The Witch’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘Charles’, ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, ‘The Lottery’.

- ‘The Witch’: Johnny is delighted, not frightened: ‘Did you cut her all in pieces?’
- ‘The Renegade’: the twins describe the collar while Jack kisses the dog’s head.
- ‘Charles’: Laurie invents Charles to report his own behaviour; the teacher: ‘We don’t have any Charles in the kindergarten.’
- ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’: the boys have not absorbed Mrs Wilson’s prejudice. Johnny: ‘She’s screwy sometimes.’ Boyd: ‘So’s mine.’
- ‘The Lottery’: ‘someone gave little Davy Hutchinson a few pebbles.’
- **Present:** Howard’s name-calling in ‘Flower Garden’; Carol’s ‘I want to go to the movies’ in ‘Of Course’.

Strong Combinations

- **Community against an outsider:** ‘The Renegade’, ‘Flower Garden’, ‘The Lottery’ (with ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’ for prejudice in a single home).
- **Women and the life they hoped for:** ‘The Daemon Lover’, ‘The Villager’, ‘Elizabeth’, ‘The Tooth’.
- **The intruder who exposes the self:** ‘Like Mother Used to Make’, ‘The Villager’, ‘The Witch’, ‘Of Course’.
- **Children as mirrors of adults:** ‘The Witch’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘Charles’, ‘The Lottery’.

Character Analysis

The Protagonist of ‘The Daemon Lover’

Unnamed and thirty-four, she is anxious, self-critical and desperate to be transformed by marriage. Her search for Jamie exposes her to the indifference and mockery of strangers. She represents the collection’s lonely women, shut out from the happiness they long for.

David Turner and Marcia (‘Like Mother Used to Make’)

David is careful, controlled and highly organised, finding pleasure in domestic order traditionally coded as feminine. Marcia is careless, loud and hungry, comfortable taking what is not hers. Their contrast challenges gender expectations, and David’s inability to assert himself leaves him excluded from his own home.

Miss Clarence (‘The Villager’)

A woman who came to the city with dreams and settled for a job. Her readiness to assume another person’s identity, and to call herself a dancer, reveals her longing to be seen as someone more interesting than she believes she is.

The Little Boy and the Stranger (‘The Witch’)

The boy, named only once (his mother calls him ‘Johnny’), is fascinated rather than frightened by violence. The stranger, friendly and well-dressed, is a figure of casual menace. The mother tries and fails to protect her son from what he has heard.

Mrs Walpole (‘The Renegade’)

An outsider in a country town, anxious to be accepted. As the community’s advice grows more violent, she comes to identify with the dog, and the story ends with her imagining the punishment closing in on her.

Laurie and His Mother (‘Charles’)

Laurie projects his own misbehaviour onto an invented boy; his mother believes every word. Together they show how people misinterpret what is in front of them and see what they want to see.

Mrs Wilson (‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’)

A well-meaning mother whose generosity rests on racial stereotypes. When Boyd challenges her assumptions, her defensiveness exposes how deeply entrenched her prejudice is.

Mrs Winning and Mrs MacLane (‘Flower Garden’)

Mrs Winning longs for independence from her husband’s family but ultimately chooses conformity, abandoning her friend. Mrs MacLane, the outsider, behaves decently and is punished for it.

Elizabeth Style ('Elizabeth')

A woman clinging to a failing career and a cooling relationship, anxious about being replaced. Her hopes in Jim Harris suggest that, like other Jackson protagonists, she imagines escape through someone else.

Clara Spencer ('The Tooth')

A wife and mother whose identity dissolves on her journey to the dentist. Her escape with the man in the blue suit is one of the few endings in the collection that breaks free of social expectations, though it may also be a breakdown.

Mrs Tylor ('Of Course')

Mrs Tylor judges her new neighbours by appearances, then feels pressured to agree with Mrs Harris's rigid views. She shows how politeness can become a form of conformity.

Tessie Hutchinson ('The Lottery')

Is Tessie a transgressor, victim or follower? She arrives late and jokes about the lottery, encourages her husband to 'get up there', and does not question the ritual until her family is chosen. She then protests that it 'wasn't fair' and even tries to include her married daughter to improve her odds. She is chosen by chance, not for any crime, and is killed by friends and family. Most readers see her as a follower who becomes a victim: her protest is against her own selection, not against the lottery itself.

The Enforcers of 'The Lottery'

- **Authority figures:** Mr Summers and Mr Graves organise the lottery and keep it running efficiently.
- **Defender of tradition:** Old Man Warner criticises villages that want to give it up and insists 'There's always been a lottery.'
- **Social conformists:** Mr Adams mentions villages that have stopped the lottery but still takes part in the stoning.
- **Complicit participants:** Mrs Delacroix, Tessie's friend, chooses a stone so large she needs both hands; Bill Hutchinson silences his wife; the children gather stones.

James Harris

Harris appears throughout the collection: as Jamie, the fiancé who vanishes in 'The Daemon Lover'; as the visitor who prompts Miss Clarence's lie in 'The Villager'; as Marcia's colleague in 'Like Mother Used to Make'; as the man in the blue suit in 'The Tooth' (and a blue-suited stranger in 'The Witch'); as the Harris family whose chickens die in 'The Renegade'; as the neighbours in 'Of Course'; and as Elizabeth's dinner date. He enters characters' lives unexpectedly, disrupts their routines and exposes problems that already exist. Some readers see him as a demon or tempter, the 'daemon lover' of the ballad that closes the book.

Literary Device Tracker

Literary Devices in *The Lottery and Other Stories*

Device	Definition / Effect	Example
Situational irony	When what happens is the opposite of what is expected.	A 'lottery' whose winner is stoned to death ('The Lottery').
Dramatic irony	When the reader knows something a character does not.	Readers suspect Laurie is Charles long before his mother does ('Charles').
Foreshadowing	Hints of what is to come.	Bobby Martin stuffing his pockets with stones ('The Lottery').
Pathetic fallacy and ironic setting	Weather or setting that mirrors, or ironically contrasts with, events and feelings.	'The morning of June 27th was clear and sunny' before a murder ('The Lottery').
Symbolism	An object, colour or action that represents an idea.	The black box; doors and windows; the man in the blue suit.
Motif	An image or idea that recurs across the collection.	James Harris; food and hunger; closed doors.
Characterisation through objects	Revealing character through possessions and spaces.	David's 'neat small table and four careful chairs' ('Like Mother Used to Make').
Character contrast	Placing characters side by side to highlight their differences.	David's order against Marcia's disorder; Mrs Winning against Mrs MacLane.
Understatement	Presenting something as less significant than it is.	The calm narration of the stoning ('The Lottery').
Dialogue	Speech that reveals character, attitudes and tension.	'Shut up, Tessie' ('The Lottery'); Mrs Wilson's offers of charity ('After You, My Dear Alphonse').
Anonymity	Leaving characters unnamed so they seem universal or diminished.	The protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover'; 'the little boy' in 'The Witch'.
Symbolic names	Names that carry meaning.	Laurie (laurels), Clara (clear, bright), Mrs Winning.
Twist ending	A final revelation that changes the meaning of the story.	'We don't have any Charles in the kindergarten' ('Charles').
Open ending	An ending that leaves key questions unanswered.	Clara running into the sand with Jim ('The Tooth').
Allusion	A reference to another text or tradition.	The comic strip behind 'After You, My Dear Alphonse'; the ballad of the Daemon Lover.
Imagery	Vivid sensory description.	'The waves ringing on the shore like bells' ('The Tooth').

Symbols and Motifs

- **Windows and Doors**
  - Represent the divide between the life characters have and the life they long for
  - Windows offer glimpses of escape and imagination: Miss Clarence dreaming of the building ‘crowned with flower gardens’, the boy looking out of the train window
  - Closed doors signal exclusion: the door that never opens at the end of ‘The Daemon Lover’
  - An open window can let chaos in, as when Marcia’s papers blow wildly around her floor
- **James Harris**
  - A recurring figure who enters ordinary lives unexpectedly and exposes hidden dissatisfaction
  - Represents the possibility of a different life, and the danger of pinning hope on it
  - Linked to the demon lover of the ballad that closes the collection
- **The Blue Suit**
  - Worn by Jim in ‘The Tooth’ and the stranger in ‘The Witch’
  - Its colour and confidence contrast with the greyness of the protagonists’ lives
- **Food and Hunger**
  - The protagonist of ‘The Daemon Lover’ finds ‘nothing to eat’, suggesting an empty life
  - David’s cooking represents care and order; Marcia, ‘always hungry’, consumes what he makes
- **Homes and Keys**
  - Homes represent identity and security; David’s single key gives him ‘a pleasant feeling’
  - Losing control of a home (David) or being trapped in someone else’s (Mrs Winning) shows loss of self
- **The Black Box and the Stones**
  - The shabby black box stands for a tradition that has lost its meaning but not its power
  - The stones, remembered when everything else is forgotten, show violence outliving reason
- **Weather**
  - Fine weather often creates an ironic contrast with cruelty or disappointment
  - Makes disturbing events seem more ordinary, and therefore more frightening
  - Can reinforce the protagonist’s bleak emotional world, or contrast with disturbing events and dissatisfaction

- ‘The Daemon Lover’: she worried ‘at the window, over whether it would be a fine day’; ‘The Lottery’: ‘clear and sunny, with the fresh warmth of a full-summer day’; ‘Flower Garden’: ‘It seems as though spring would never come… I get so tired of the cold’; ‘Elizabeth’: a dream of ‘a hot sunny garden’, then ‘it was raining’; ‘The Tooth’: ‘she ran barefoot through hot sand’; ‘Like Mother Used to Make’: papers ‘blown wildly around the floor’

- **Children**
  - Reveal the hidden prejudices and cruelty of the adults around them
  - Sometimes resist adult attitudes, exposing their absurdity
  - ‘Flower Garden’: Howard’s immediate racist name-calling towards Billy Jones expresses the racism around him, but his innocent wish to play with Davey exposes how prejudiced his mother is being in shutting out Mrs MacLane
  - ‘The Witch’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, ‘Charles’ and ‘The Lottery’ all show children absorbing, testing or exposing adult values
- **Gardens and Flowers**
  - In ‘Flower Garden’, the garden represents Mrs MacLane’s independence and her friendship with Mrs Winning
  - Its growth through the work of Mr Jones becomes the cause of her exclusion
- **Names**
  - Unnamed characters seem anonymous and universal
  - Symbolic names (Laurie, Clara, Winning, Walpole) carry ironic meaning

Written Exemplars

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Ideas & interpretation | Language & technique | Structure & evidence

Written Exemplars

Sample 1: Model *The Lottery and Other Stories* Paragraph

Topic: **The desire for social acceptance shapes the behaviour of many of Jackson's characters. Do you agree?**

This paragraph uses a structure that works well for a collection: topic sentence, story one, link, story two, synthesising sentence.

In many of her stories, Jackson depicts characters whose need for social acceptance is so strong that they repress or lie about aspects of themselves to appear more desirable or successful to others. In 'The Daemon Lover', the unnamed protagonist seeks social acceptance and happiness through marriage. Though the protagonist knows she is 'haggard and lined', she is unable to accept that on the day of her supposed wedding, her 'young' fiancé is missing because he has used and jilted her. When she finally locates him, her unwillingness to admit the truth results in her coming back to his door 'many times', where she is always locked out, representing that this dream is not possible for her. 'The Villager' also features a character who lies to herself and others in an attempt to appear more successful. In this story, Miss Clarence tells herself she has 'a good job' and is living 'better than she would have in her home town'. But this attitude disguises a discontent that she has not pursued the dreams of being a dancer she had when she was younger. She compulsively lies to a stranger that she is a 'dancer', revealing her desire to be seen as someone more accomplished and interesting than she believes herself to be. At the story's end, Jackson describes how the protagonist's 'shoulders ached', symbolically representing the burden of carrying dissatisfaction. Through these examples, Jackson demonstrates that the desire to be accepted and admired by others can cause individuals to construct false identities and deny the bitter reality of their lives.

Sample 2: Model *The Lottery and Other Stories* Essay

Topic: **Jackson's stories suggest that ordinary social settings can conceal disturbing cruelty. Discuss.**

Introduction

Shirley Jackson's *The Lottery and Other Stories* (1949) is set in the most familiar places imaginable: city apartments, trains, small-town streets and village squares. Yet beneath these ordinary surfaces Jackson uncovers cruelty that is all the more disturbing for being so casual. Through stories such as 'The Lottery', 'The Renegade', 'The Witch' and 'Flower Garden', Jackson suggests that cruelty is learned, normalised and enforced by respectable people, and that the polite rituals of community life can disguise, and even sustain, a deep lack of compassion.

Body Paragraph 1

Jackson's most chilling insight is that the familiar rituals of community life can sanction violence, as 'The Lottery' makes devastatingly clear. The story opens on a morning that is 'clear and sunny, with the fresh warmth of a full-summer day', and the villagers gather to chat about 'planting and rain, tractors and taxes'. This deliberately ordinary setting, narrated in a calm, understated voice, lulls the reader into expecting a harmless civic event. The tradition is upheld by authority figures, Mr Summers and Mr Graves, and defended by Old Man Warner, who dismisses villages that have abandoned it as a 'pack of crazy fools' and insists 'there's always been a lottery'. Even Mr Adams, who mentions that other villages are 'talking of giving up the lottery', joins the crowd at the end. That 'although the villagers had forgotten the ritual and lost the original black box, they still remembered to use stones' suggests a violence that has outlived any meaning the tradition once had. By embedding a murder in the routine of a village fair, Jackson exposes how communities can perform cruelty while believing themselves civilised.

Body Paragraph 2

Jackson further suggests that cruelty is passed on through everyday family life, as children learn from the adults around them what is normal. In 'The Renegade', Mrs Walpole's neighbours respond to her dog's killing of chickens with cheerful, increasingly violent advice, and her own children delight in imagining how a spiked collar would make 'the spikes cut her head off'. Their laughter turns a domestic problem into a scene of shocking cruelty, and the story ends with Mrs Walpole 'suddenly feeling the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat', as if the community's violence had turned on her. Similarly, in 'The Witch', a friendly stranger on a train tells a little boy that he 'cut off her head and her hands', and the boy responds not with fear but with breathless excitement: 'Did you cut her all in pieces?' The pleasant setting of a train journey, complete with a baby 'busy with her rattle and her toast', makes the boy's fascination deeply unsettling. Through these children, Jackson reveals that cruelty is not an aberration but something absorbed and repeated within ordinary homes. The same acceptance of violence appears in 'The Lottery', where 'someone gave little Davy Hutchinson a few pebbles'.

Body Paragraph 3

However, Jackson's cruelty is not always physical: in many stories it takes the quieter form of exclusion, enforced through polite social behaviour. In 'Flower Garden', the town never openly attacks Mrs MacLane; instead, neighbours advise Mrs Winning to speak to her 'about that colored man', and Mrs MacLane recognises that soon 'they'll tell someone else to speak to me'. The cruelty lies in silence and withdrawal, culminating as Mrs Winning turns away 'without speaking' and walks 'with great dignity' back to the old Winning house. The phrase 'great dignity' is bitterly ironic: respectability itself is the instrument of exclusion. In 'After You, My Dear Alphonse', Mrs Wilson's apparently generous offers to Boyd are built on racist assumptions, and her offence when he declines shows how prejudice can hide behind kindness. In these stories, Jackson suggests that the most damaging cruelty is often performed by people who believe they are behaving well.

Conclusion

Across *The Lottery and Other Stories*, Jackson reveals that ordinary social settings are not refuges from cruelty but often its source. Whether in the ritual of the village lottery, the casual advice of neighbours, a story told on a train, or the polite withdrawal of a friend, Jackson exposes a society in which violence and prejudice are normalised beneath a civilised surface.

Her quiet, matter-of-fact style ensures that readers recognise these communities as their own, and that recognition is what makes her stories so disturbing.

Sample 3: Essay Plan

Topic: **Unexpected encounters force confrontation with uncomfortable truths. How is this idea explored in Jackson's stories?**

Contention

Jackson uses unexpected encounters to expose the dissatisfaction, prejudice and cruelty that already lie beneath ordinary lives, though her characters do not always confront these truths; often they retreat from them.

BP1: Jackson uses unexpected encounters to expose individuals' dissatisfaction with their identities and their desire for a different life.

- 'The Villager': Harris's unexpected arrival prompts Miss Clarence to invent a more successful identity as a 'dancer', exposing her disappointment with her own life; 'Her shoulders ached.'
- 'The Tooth': the man in the blue suit offers Clara visions of 'the waves ringing on the shore like bells', exposing her longing to escape her grey life.

BP2: Jackson portrays unexpected encounters as exposing the prejudices and cruelty that exist beneath the polite surface of society.

- 'After You, My Dear Alphonse': Boyd's visit exposes Mrs Wilson's racist assumptions beneath her 'kindness'.
- 'The Witch': the stranger's violent story exposes the boy's fascination with cruelty and the mother's powerlessness to control what he learns.
- 'Of Course': the new neighbours expose the pressure to conform behind neighbourly politeness.

BP3: However, Jackson also suggests that unexpected encounters do not always lead to genuine confrontation; characters often avoid the truth.

- 'Like Mother Used to Make': Mr Harris's arrival exposes David's passivity, but David fails to challenge Marcia's assumption of ownership over his home.
- 'The Daemon Lover': the protagonist refuses to admit she has been jilted and keeps knocking at a door that never opens.
- 'Charles': Laurie's mother learns the truth only at the very end, after weeks of choosing not to see it.

Section A Sample Essays: *The Lottery* (Low, Medium and High)

Topic: **In Jackson's 'The Lottery', the villagers conform because they are afraid of being excluded. To what extent do you agree?**

Sample Essay I (Low)

Introduction

In 'The Lottery', Shirley Jackson shows a village that follows a ritual without question. I agree that the villagers conform because they are afraid of being excluded. Jackson uses tradition, Tessie Hutchinson and the crowd to show this.
Body Paragraph 1

Jackson shows that tradition keeps the villagers in line. The villagers all come to the square on time. Mrs Graves and Mrs Delacroix talk and laugh while they wait. This shows the villagers are friendly , but they still follow the lottery because it is what they have always done. Old Man Warner says 'There's always been a lottery', which shows they will not change.
Body Paragraph 2 So fear of breaking with the ritual is what keeps them coming back.

Jackson shows that people silence anyone who breaks with the group. Tessie is the only one who complains. She says 'It isn't fair, it isn't right'. The other villagers tell her to be a good sport. This shows people are afraid of being different, so they make her quiet.
Body Paragraph 3 So conformity is enforced by pressure as much as by belief.

The final scene shows the crowd acting on its fear. At the end, the villagers pick up stones. Old Man Warner tells everyone to come on. This shows the crowd is scared and wants to join in so they are not left out.
Conclusion This is the result of conforming out of fear of being excluded.

Jackson shows the villagers conform because they are afraid. So I agree with the statement.
Sample Essay II (Medium)

Introduction

In 'The Lottery', Shirley Jackson presents a village whose members gather each June to take part in a ritual none of them questions. I agree that the villagers conform out of fear of being excluded, though the story suggests the fear is learned rather than simply felt. Jackson builds the pressure through the power of tradition, the crowd's manners and the way Tessie is isolated.
Body Paragraph 1

The villagers do not discuss the lottery; they simply attend it. Old Man Warner dismisses the talk of change as 'Pack of crazy fools', and insists 'There's always been a lottery.' His certainty shows that the ritual survives because nobody is willing to be the one who breaks it. The narration confirms this, noting that no one liked to upset 'even as much tradition as was represented by the black box'.
Body Paragraph 2 That is why the ritual survives, even though nobody defends it.

Tessie's protest is what exposes the fear. When she cries 'It isn't fair, it isn't right', her neighbours do not argue the point. Mrs Delacroix calls 'Be a good sport, Tessie', and Mrs Graves reminds her that 'All of us took the same chance.' The phrase is a warning: conformity is presented as fairness, and dissent is treated as poor manners .
Body Paragraph 3 Conformity is therefore presented as the reasonable choice.

The stoning shows what exclusion finally looks like. Once Tessie is singled out, the crowd moves towards her, and Old Man Warner's 'Come on, come on, everyone' pushes the reluctant villagers into the action. The fear of being left out is greater than any sympathy for Tessie , and

the villagers join in rather than stand apart.
Conclusion Fear of exclusion, not sympathy, decides what the crowd does.

Jackson shows that the villagers conform because exclusion is worse than the violence they must commit. The ritual is kept alive by people who would rather be part of the crowd than face being the outsider. The fear is real, so even if it is never spoken, it shapes every choice the villagers make.
Sample Essay III (High)

Introduction

Shirley Jackson opens 'The Lottery' with a morning that is 'clear and sunny', and the pleasantness is the first thing the story asks us to distrust . I agree that the villagers conform because they fear exclusion, but Jackson's argument is more unsettling than that. The villagers are not forced. They have learned to read their own belonging as something they must keep up, and the fear of being separated from the crowd does the rest. Jackson builds this through the normality of the ritual, the inheritance of tradition and the isolation of Tessie.
Body Paragraph 1

The story frames the ritual as ordinary. The children assemble first, 'of course', and the women talk among themselves while they wait. Mrs Hutchinson arrives late, having 'clean forgot what day it was', which suggests the lottery is so routine that it can be forgotten and still be attended. Conformity starts before anybody is asked to conform , because the day has already been made normal.
Body Paragraph 2 Conformity therefore begins in the ordinary, before any fear is needed.

Old Man Warner shows how conformity is passed down. He calls the north village's doubts 'Pack of crazy fools', then offers the proverb 'Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon'. He is not defending the lottery on grounds of safety; he links it to survival, so anyone who questions it threatens the community's shared sense of its own security. The narration's aside that no one liked to upset 'even as much tradition as was represented by the black box' shows that the tradition has outlasted any reason for it.
Body Paragraph 3 The tradition survives because each generation learns the same fear.

Tessie's protest is what exposes the mechanism. Her 'It isn't fair, it isn't right' is met with 'Be a good sport, Tessie', and then with Mrs Graves's 'All of us took the same chance.' That reply turns fairness into a matter of who is willing to play along . The crowd's first move against her is verbal before it is physical. By the time the stones fly, Tessie has already been reduced to someone who must be silenced so that everyone else can feel safe in their place.
Conclusion Exclusion is the mechanism, and the crowd's fear of it keeps the ritual going.

Jackson's village conforms because each person has been taught that the group's approval is the only safety available. The black box, the proverbs and the good-sport rhetoric all teach that the outsider is the real danger. I agree with the statement, though the story suggests that fear of exclusion is not merely a motive. It is the mechanism that keeps the lottery alive.

Section A Sample Essays: *The Lottery* (Low, Medium and High)

Topic: **Jackson suggests that tradition is more powerful than reason. Do you agree?**

Sample Essay I (Low)

Introduction

In 'The Lottery', Shirley Jackson shows a village that keeps a ritual even though nobody can explain why. I agree that tradition is more powerful than reason in the story. Jackson uses the villagers' sayings, the black box and the response to Tessie Hutchinson to show this.

Body Paragraph 1

Old Man Warner says 'There's always been a lottery'. This shows that tradition is important to the villagers. He also calls the people who want to stop 'Pack of crazy fools'. This shows that tradition wins over reason. Tradition is what keeps the lottery going. So the village keeps the lottery because it has always done so, not because it makes sense.

Body Paragraph 2

The saying 'Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon' is repeated as if it were a reason. Nobody questions it. This shows the saying is more powerful than thinking. So reason never gets a hearing in the village.

Body Paragraph 3

At the end, the villagers pick up stones, and 'Come on, come on, everyone' is said. This shows tradition is stronger than the people . So the ending proves the same point.

Conclusion

Jackson shows tradition is more powerful than reason. So I agree with the statement.

Sample Essay II (Medium)

Introduction

In 'The Lottery', Shirley Jackson presents a village that continues a ritual no one can justify. I agree that tradition is more powerful than reason, though the story suggests that tradition survives partly through fear. Jackson builds this through the saying the villagers repeat, the black box nobody will replace and the way the crowd answers Tessie Hutchinson's appeal to fairness.

Body Paragraph 1

Jackson shows that the villagers keep the lottery because of what they have always done, not because of any reason they can give. Old Man Warner insists 'There's always been a lottery', and the proverb 'Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon' is repeated as though it explains everything. The proverb ties the ritual to the harvest, a practical concern, but nobody checks whether the connection is real; the saying is accepted because it is old. Tradition therefore has force even where the reason behind it has disappeared.

Body Paragraph 2

The black box shows how far the village has let tradition outlast its meaning . The narration notes that no one liked to upset 'even as much tradition as was represented by the black box',

and Mr Summers's repeated talk of making a new box never leads to one. The village would rather keep an old box than change a ritual whose reason has been lost. The object carries the practice when the reasons have gone.

Body Paragraph 3

Reason is answered with social pressure, not argument. When Tessie protests 'It isn't fair, it isn't right', Mrs Delacroix replies 'Be a good sport, Tessie', and Mrs Graves adds that 'All of us took the same chance.' Neither reply addresses whether the drawing was fair; both appeal to belonging. So when reason is raised, tradition answers with the pressure of the group, and the ritual continues.

Conclusion

Jackson shows that the lottery survives because tradition has outlived its reasons and reason has no way to win against the group. I agree, though fear of exclusion is part of why tradition wins.

Sample Essay III (High)

Introduction

Shirley Jackson opens 'The Lottery' with a morning that is 'clear and sunny', and with a village that gathers without asking why. I agree that tradition is more powerful than reason, but the story shows that this power is not simply habit. Jackson builds it through the proverbs the villagers repeat, the black box they will not replace and the social pressure that answers Tessie Hutchinson's appeal to fairness.

Body Paragraph 1

The proverbs carry tradition as if it were knowledge. The saying 'Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon' links the ritual to survival, and Old Man Warner warns that without it 'we'd all be eating stewed chickweed and acorns'. The claim is a warning rather than an argument . It sets the ritual against hunger, which is why questioning the lottery sounds reckless. Reason has no part in a proverb that presents the ritual as the thing that keeps people fed, and so tradition gains its power by seeming practical .

Body Paragraph 2

The black box shows that tradition can outlast its own materials. The narration says the villagers 'had forgotten the ritual and lost the original black box, they still remembered to use stones'. The ritual has become detached from its objects, yet its violence remains. Tradition persists in what it demands even when its form has gone, and the stones are the one part of the ritual the village has never let go of.

Body Paragraph 3

Reason has no hearing once the crowd has decided . Tessie's argument is about fairness, 'It isn't fair, it isn't right', and she is answered with 'Be a good sport, Tessie' and 'All of us took the same chance.' The replies concern belonging, not fairness. 'Come on, come on, everyone' turns the crowd towards her, and 'A stone hit her on the side of the head' shows where the argument ends. So tradition wins not by being right but by being shared .

Conclusion

Jackson shows that tradition is more powerful than reason because it does not need to be justified: it survives in proverbs, in objects and in the pressure to belong. I agree, though the story also shows what that power costs.